

# Is Critical Race Theory Biblical?

*Race, Justice, and What the Church Actually Owes the World*

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JAMES C. BELL

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## INTRODUCTION

# The Argument That Broke the American Church

*Why critical race theory divided Christians, and what  
Scripture says that neither side wanted to hear*

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*The American church did not have a  
race problem because Critical Race  
Theory arrived. The church had a  
race problem. CRT simply exposed it.*

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WHY CRITICAL RACE THEORY EXPOSED  
WHAT THE CHURCH WAS ALREADY HIDING

not have a race problem because Critical Race Theory arrived. The church had a race problem. CRT simply exposed it, and when people saw what was underneath, they panicked.

Some panicked on the right, seeing CRT as a Marxist assault on Christianity itself—an ideology that would reduce people to racial categories, weaponize guilt, and destroy the church from within. They mobilized, passed resolutions, drew lines, and said no. Others panicked on the left, seeing CRT as finally naming what white Christianity had been hiding for four hundred years; they adopted it wholesale, expected the white church to confess, repent, and dismantle itself, and said yes to everything they heard.

Both responses were panic. Neither was thinking. This book refuses both.

## **WHAT THIS BOOK IS NOT — NEITHER DEFENSE NOR DISMISSAL OF CRT**

**THIS IS NOT A** defense of Critical Race Theory, which has genuine problems: it operates from anthropological assumptions that contradict the Christian vision of the human person, it often settles for justice without reconciliation, and it flattens complexity in service of a metanarrative. The Bible's vision of justice is more searching than CRT—not less—which means the Christian response to CRT cannot be capitulation.

This is also not a dismissal of CRT. The academics who built it—Derrick Bell, Kimberlé Crenshaw, Richard Delgado—were making specific claims about how law and social systems embed racial bias, and those claims deserve to be understood before they are rejected. Most people who attack

This book is something else. It asks what Scripture actually teaches about race, ethnicity, justice, and the image of God; how the American church—a church built on the gospel of reconciliation—became the institution that defended slavery, maintained segregation, and then panicked when confronted with its own history; and what it would look like if the church offered the world something more searching than either progressive ideology or conservative denial.

### **THE REAL CRISIS: THE CHURCH HAD NO CREDIBLE ALTERNATIVE**

**THE CRISIS IS NOT** that CRT exists. The crisis is that when CRT arrived, the American church had no credible alternative—no theology of justice forged in suffering, no prophetic tradition that could speak with authority, and a four-hundred-year history it had never honestly reckoned with.

So when CRT showed up saying, "Your systems are rigged, and you have been lying about it," the white church's response was not, "The Bible speaks more deeply to this than CRT does." The response was either defensive—CRT is Marxism, don't listen—or confused: maybe CRT is right, we don't know what else to do. Both responses revealed the same thing. The American church had lost its own voice on racial justice. That is the real crisis.

### **WHAT SCRIPTURE ALREADY SAYS ABOUT JUSTICE AND RECONCILIATION**

own justice theology, and it is not found in CRT textbooks; it is found in Exodus, in the prophets, in Jesus's reading of Isaiah in the synagogue, in Paul's letter to Philemon. It says that God cares about systems that oppress the vulnerable, that ethnicity is real and beautiful and never grounds for hierarchy, that the cross breaks every power structure—including racial ones—and that justice must precede reconciliation, with reconciliation made possible only through the blood of Christ.

That vision is more demanding than CRT. It demands more. It offers more. And the American church has largely abandoned it—the conservatives by denying systemic injustice exists, the progressives by adopting a secular structure that offers no power to actually reconcile divided people. Both fail to read their own Scripture.

## WHO THIS BOOK IS FOR

**THIS BOOK IS FOR** the Christian who is confused. You have heard that CRT is a threat; you have also heard that the church's silence on racial justice is a sin; and you don't know who to trust. You want to think clearly about this, to know what Scripture actually says, to hold both prophetic conviction and pastoral love, and to refuse both cheap conservatism and uncritical progressivism. This book is for you.

It is also for the pastor who senses that his congregation is divided on this issue and has no structure to lead them. It is for the Christian parent raising children in a world confused about race. And it is for the person who has been harmed by the church's racial history and wants to know if there is



## THE ARGUMENT AHEAD

**WE WILL START BY** actually understanding what CRT says—not the caricature, not the political attacks, but what the academics actually wrote, because you need to understand what you are disagreeing with. Then we will turn to Scripture: what the Bible teaches about race and ethnicity, what it says about systemic injustice, what it demands of the people of God regarding the vulnerable and the oppressed.

Then we will do what the American church has largely refused to do, and look honestly at our own history—how the church defended slavery, what theology was used to justify segregation, when evangelicals realigned around race, what we did during the civil rights movement. The answers are not comfortable, but you cannot understand the present crisis without understanding that history.

Then we will look at what CRT gets right—not because CRT is in the end true, but because the Bible also names these truths—and at where CRT gets it wrong: where it contradicts the gospel's anthropology, where it offers justice without reconciliation, where it flattens the complexity of the human person. Finally, we will ask what the church owes the world on race. Not performative diversity. Not guilty self-flagellation. Not denial. But genuine justice pursued through the power of the gospel, leading to genuine reconciliation made possible only through Christ's blood.

## ONE MORE THING

pastor. I am American. I have benefited from systems built on racial injustice, and I inherited that benefit; I was raised in ignorance of that history, and I have made mistakes in how I have handled race from the pulpit—I have been too cautious, I have been defensive, I have offered false reconciliation before genuine justice. I am in this indictment. This book is not me looking down at people who got it wrong; it is me looking at the room I am standing in and naming what I see. That matters. If I am not in this, you should not listen to me.

The work of racial justice in the American church is long and painful, requiring confession and repentance that goes deeper than words, structural change that costs something, leaders willing to admit what they have gotten wrong. The gospel demands it. The vulnerable demand it. History demands it.

But the gospel also offers something no secular justice movement can offer: the possibility of genuine reconciliation, the possibility of the cross actually breaking what divides us, the possibility of people who have been harmed and people who have done harm becoming one people again—not by pretending the harm didn't happen, but by moving through confession, restitution, and the blood of Christ. That is the hope this book holds. Not the cheap hope that says everything will be fine. The costly hope that says the work is real, the cost is real, and Christ has already paid the ultimate cost. Read on.

## CHAPTER 1

# What Critical Race Theory Actually Says

*A fair summary of what CRT scholars actually claim  
— before you agree or disagree*

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**BEFORE YOU CAN HONESTLY** engage with Critical Race Theory, you have to know what it actually says — not the caricature, not what conservative or progressive activists claim it says, but what the academics who created it wrote. Most people have never read a single work by a CRT scholar. They have read Twitter attacks on it; they have heard sermons warning against it; they have seen listicles claiming it is Marxism. They have adopted or rejected an entire intellectual structure without understanding what is in it.

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*If you are going to disagree with  
something, you owe it to yourself and*

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**THAT IS INTELLECTUAL LAZINESS.** That is not thinking. That is panic. If you are going to disagree with something, you owe it to yourself and to everyone listening to disagree with what it actually says — and that begins with reading the people who built it.

### **THE ORIGINS OF CRT: DERRICK BELL AND THE LAW SCHOOL**

**CRITICAL RACE THEORY WAS** born in American law schools in the 1980s, and its intellectual father was Derrick Bell, a Black law professor at Harvard. Bell was not trying to create a revolutionary ideology; he was trying to answer a legal question that the formal victories of the era had left unresolved: why, despite the Civil Rights Act of 1964, did racial inequality persist in America?

The conservative answer is straightforward. The law is neutral now, racism is individual, and if you work hard you will succeed; any ongoing racial inequality is personal failure, not systemic bias. Bell looked at the legal record and rejected that account, because he saw patterns — that even after formal laws changed, the racial outcomes did not change proportionally, and that institutions continued to embed racial bias into their structures, not always through explicit rules but through facially neutral rules that nonetheless had racial effect.

## INTERSECTIONALITY EXPLAINED: KIMBERLÉ CRENSHAW'S CONTRIBUTION

**DERRICK BELL'S WORK WAS** primarily about race and law. In the early 1990s, Kimberlé Crenshaw expanded the system with a concept she called intersectionality, and her starting point was a simple observation: a Black woman does not experience racism the way a Black man does, nor does she experience sexism the way a white woman does. Her experience is not racism plus sexism; it is a distinct experience created by the intersection of race and gender together.

Crenshaw's broader argument was that people carry multiple identities and that systems of power operate through multiple axes — race, gender, class, sexuality, disability — so that a person's lived experience depends on where they sit in relation to all of those axes at once. Again, this is not inherently revolutionary; it is an observation about complexity. But it became revolutionary when Crenshaw drew the conclusion plainly: if you want to understand injustice, you cannot study race without studying gender, and you cannot study gender without studying class, because the systems are interlocking.

## THE CORE CLAIMS OF CRITICAL RACE THEORY

**RICHARD DELGADO AND JEAN** Stefancic took CRT from

The first claim is that race is a social construct, not a biological reality — and this is widely misunderstood. When CRT scholars say race is a social construct, they do not mean race is not real; they mean that the categories white, Black, Asian, and the rest are human inventions, created to serve a function, which was to organize power. The biological reality is human genetic variation. The social reality is that we organized that variation into racial categories and built hierarchies on top of them.

This is historically true. The concept of whiteness, as we understand it, did not exist in the seventeenth century; it was constructed. Irish people were not white. Jews were not white. Mexicans were not white. Over time the boundaries shifted and people moved in and out of whiteness — which is the very definition of a social construct, something human-made rather than natural.

The Bible teaches the same thing. Genesis 10 lists nations, the prophets speak of tribes, and Revelation 7 celebrates diverse peoples; nowhere does Scripture teach that racial hierarchy is natural or God-ordained. If it has been constructed to justify injustice, it can be deconstructed.

The second claim is that racism is systemic, not merely individual, and this is the claim that most threatens the conservative narrative. CRT scholars argue that racism is not primarily about individual prejudice but about power structures embedded in how institutions function. Consider a

Is that discrimination? Legally, it depends on intent. The bank did not intend racial discrimination, but the effect is racial discrimination — and here CRT becomes more searching than the law allows. The law asks whether you intended discrimination; CRT asks whether your systems perpetuate racial inequality. Those are different questions, and CRT scholars insist the effect matters more than the intent: if your neutral systems produce racial outcomes, your systems are serving racism, whether or not your heart is racist.

The third claim is epistemological: the lived experience of marginalized people is a legitimate source of knowledge. If you want to understand how racism actually operates in America, you should listen to people who have experienced it, because their lived experience is not merely anecdotal — it is data. CRT scholars argue that American law and American policy have largely been designed by people in the majority group without adequately listening to people in the marginalized group, with the result that policy often misses the actual impact of systems on the people they affect.

The Bible teaches this same thing. Psalm 82 says God hears the cry of the afflicted; Proverbs 31 says open your mouth for the mute; the prophets constantly charge that you have not listened to the poor, the widow, the stranger. Their

The fourth claim is that the law can be an instrument of racial oppression, and this is obvious when you read American legal history. The law once explicitly protected slavery, created segregation, allowed redlining — the explicit denial of mortgages based on race — and built Jim Crow. But CRT's claim goes deeper, arguing that even after formal laws changed, the legal system can continue to serve racial oppression through facially neutral mechanisms: the war on drugs, sentencing disparities, qualified immunity for police are not explicitly racial laws, yet they have racial effects.

This is not a fringe argument; it is supported by mountains of data. Sentencing disparities between Black and white defendants for identical crimes are real, the racial impact of drug laws is real, and the data is overwhelming.

### **WHAT CRITICAL RACE THEORY DOES NOT SAY**

**BEFORE MOVING ON, IT** is worth naming what CRT scholars do not actually claim, because this is where the caricature departs from reality. CRT does not say all white people are oppressors. It does not say all Black people are victims. It does not say racism is genetic or that white people are inherently racist. It does not claim that individual prejudice does not matter. And it does not say that wealth disparities are solely the result of racism, though it does treat racism as one significant factor among many.

The actual claim is narrower: racial categories were created to organize power, systems continue to distribute that power along racial lines, and understanding this requires



## WHERE CHRISTIANS SHOULD LISTEN AND WHERE CHRISTIANS MUST QUESTION

**THE BIBLE TEACHES SEVERAL** things that align with CRT's diagnosis, even if CRT's solutions are inadequate. It teaches that God cares about systems that oppress the vulnerable; Exodus is not just the story of individual redemption but of liberation from an economic system that enslaved people, and the prophets do not merely call individuals to stop exploiting the poor — they call for jubilee, for structural debt forgiveness, for the return of land, for systems that protect the vulnerable.

Scripture also teaches that sin has corporate dimensions. Nehemiah confessed the sins of his ancestors; Daniel confessed the sins of his people; the concept that a people can share guilt for institutional injustice is thoroughly biblical. And it teaches that lived experience matters in bearing witness. Job's friends came to comfort him, but when they heard his testimony they had to reconsider their theology; the disciples had to hear the witness of women before they believed in the resurrection; Peter had to hear Cornelius's witness before he understood that the gospel was for gentiles. When people tell you what they have experienced, you do not get to dismiss it because it does not fit your theory.

These are not CRT arguments. These are biblical

But CRT's structure also conflicts with Christian anthropology in important ways. CRT tends to see identity as primarily group-based and defined by power relationships, so that a person's essence becomes their position in the system — oppressor or oppressed — and society is understood at its core as organized around these power categories. Christianity sees identity as primarily rooted in the image of God: every person, regardless of race or status, bears the divine image, an image that cannot be taken away by power or privilege and cannot be conferred by victimization. My identity is not my racial category or my oppressor status. My identity is God's beloved, redeemed through Christ.

This is not a minor difference; it is anthropological, and it changes how we understand justice. CRT often works backward from systems to see what people are. Christianity works backward from the image of God to see what every person is — and therefore what justice demands. CRT can name systems accurately. Christianity can offer transformation that CRT cannot.

## THE POINT

**THE POINT OF THIS** chapter is simple: understand what you are debating. Read Derrick Bell. Read Kimberlé Crenshaw. Read Richard Delgado's introduction to CRT. Then you can make an informed judgment about where CRT is right and where it is wrong.

You owe yourself that work. You owe the person you are speaking with that work. The conversation is worth having — but it is worth having with clarity, not panic. Read the texts. Then think. Then speak.

## CHAPTER 2

# What the Bible Actually Says About Race, Ethnicity, and the Image of God

*The image of God, the goodness of ethnicity, and the prophets' demand for justice*

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### THE IMAGE OF GOD IS UNIVERSAL AND CANNOT BE CURSED

**IF YOU ARE GOING** to think biblically about race, you have to begin where Scripture begins: every human being bears the image of God. That is not a sentiment to be admired; it is the premise everything else stands on.

*So God created mankind in his own image, in the image of God he created them; male and female he created*

GENESIS 1:27

**READ THE VERSE CAREFULLY**, because the precision is the point. Not "males bear the image." Not "people of certain races bear the image." All mankind. The imago Dei is universal; it is not earned, it cannot be taken away by circumstance or power, and it is constitutive of what it means to be human at all.

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*If a person bears the image of God,  
then every attempt to reduce them to  
a category is an assault on the image  
of God himself.*

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**EVERYTHING IN THIS CHAPTER** flows from that single foundation. If a person does not bear the image of God—if they are somehow less fully human—then hierarchy and exploitation become, in their own cold way, logical. But if they do bear it, then every attempt to reduce them to a category, to extract their labor, to deny them dignity, is an assault on the image of God himself.

This is precisely the foundation the American church tried to erode. It defended slavery by carving out exceptions to the imago Dei: cursed Hamites, they said; natural slaves, they said; less developed, they said—each argument a way of claiming that some humans bore the image more fully than others. Scripture will not allow that argument. The image of God is not partial. Not hierarchical. Not dependent on race,

## ETHNICITY IS REAL AND GOOD IN SCRIPTURE

**HERE IS WHERE THE** Christian teaching on race grows complicated in the best way: ethnicity is real, and it is good. In Acts 17, standing before the philosophers of the Areopagus, Paul tells the Athenians that "from one man he made all the nations, that they should inhabit the whole earth; and he marked out their appointed times in history and the boundaries of their lands."

God made nations. God marked out their boundaries. God appointed their times. Ethnicity, then, is not a mistake to be erased; it is intentional, woven deliberately into creation. This is why the most-quoted verse on the subject is so often misread.

*There is neither Jew nor Gentile, neither slave nor free,  
nor is there male and female, for you are all one in  
Christ Jesus.*

GALATIANS 3:28

**PEOPLE REACH FOR THAT** verse to argue that ethnicity does not matter, but that is not what Paul is saying. He is not denying that Jew and Gentile are different; he is insisting that in Christ those differences no longer create hierarchy. The distinction remains—the ranking is abolished.

And the final vision of Scripture confirms it, because the end is not a homogenized humanity. Revelation 7 shows "a great multitude that no one could count, from every nation, tribe, people and language, standing before the throne and

## THE CURSE OF HAM: WHAT SCRIPTURE SAYS AND WHAT THE CHURCH INVENTED

**THE MOST CONSEQUENTIAL LIE** the American church ever told about Scripture was the doctrine of the "curse of Ham." To see how consequential, you have to start with the text itself, which is sparse and strange. Noah gets drunk and lies naked in his tent; his son Ham sees his nakedness and tells his brothers; the brothers cover him without looking; Noah wakes and pronounces a curse—not on Ham, but on Canaan, the son of Ham.

*Cursed be Canaan! The lowest of slaves will he be to his brothers.*

GENESIS 9:25

**THAT IS THE ENTIRE** text. A father, dishonored, curses a grandson. Now hear what American preachers did with it. They took the curse of Canaan and mapped it onto Black Africans; they argued that Canaan was the ancestor of African peoples, that God had marked Black people for slavery, and they made this single curse the biblical justification for the entire enterprise of American bondage. Every major theological defense of American slavery leaned on the curse of Ham.

First, the curse of Canaan has nothing to do with Africa or with the descendants of Ham in general. Canaan is one son, and the curse falls on him specifically; historically the Canaanites were the people who lived in the land that became Israel, which is why the text explains the conquest of Canaan in Joshua, not the peopling of a continent. Second, even if it somehow applied to African peoples, it would still be overridden, because the curse says "cursed be Canaan" while the foundation says "in God's image he made them"—and when the foundation is the image of God, no curse can justify slavery. Third, the whole arc of Scripture bends the other way: Jesus comes to reverse curses, to restore what was broken, to make unmistakable that the image of God cannot be cursed, cannot be enslaved, cannot be reduced to property.

The doctrine of the curse of Ham is the American church's most explicit sin against Scripture. We invented it. We weaponized it. We used the word of God to justify the enslavement of millions—and that history has consequences still playing out.

## **WHAT THE PROPHETS SAY ABOUT SYSTEMIC INJUSTICE**

**IF YOU WANT TO** know what the Bible says about what we now call systemic injustice, you have to read the prophets, because they did not confine sin to the individual heart. Amos stands up and thunders against an



*Hear this, you who tread upon the poor and who trample upon the needy... The Lord has sworn by the Pride of Jacob: 'I will never forget anything they have done.'*

AMOS 8:4-7

**NOTICE THAT AMOS IS** not merely calling individual rich men bad people; he is naming a system—treading, trampling—that manufactures poverty. The system has human agents, but the judgment falls on the system itself. Isaiah goes further and names the machinery directly.

*Woe to those who enact unjust decrees and write oppressive laws, depriving the poor of justice and robbing the needy of their rights... What will you do on the day of reckoning, when disaster comes from afar?*

ISAIAH 10:1-3

**THAT IS A PROPHET** talking about law: unjust law, statutes that look neutral on their face yet produce oppression, laws drafted by the powerful to benefit the powerful while the poor are left defenseless. Micah names the violence of it in the most visceral terms.

*Hear, you heads of Jacob and rulers of Israel... You hate good and love evil; you tear the skin from my people and the flesh from their bones... Will you not be ashamed of your shameful deeds?*

MICAH 3:1-7

**THIS IS NOT INDIVIDUAL** sin. This is systemic violence—a structure of power that enriches some while destroying others. The prophets read the structures of their societies

This is also the point where the Bible's vision becomes more searching than critical race theory, and it is worth saying plainly so neither side mishears it. CRT can name systems; the Bible names systems and offers power to transform them. But the starting point is the same. Systems matter. Structures matter. It is not enough to change hearts if the structures that perpetuate harm are left standing.

### **CORPORATE SIN, INHERITED GUILT, AND THE JUBILEE**

**ONE OF THE STRANGEST** parts of Scripture for Western Christians is the concept of corporate sin—the idea that a people can bear guilt for the sins of previous generations or for the sins embedded in their systems. Nehemiah models it without flinching.

*Lord... We have acted very wickedly toward you. We have not obeyed the commands, decrees and laws you gave your servant Moses.*

NEHEMIAH 1:5-7

**NEHEMIAH WAS NOT PERSONALLY** responsible for the sins he confesses; his ancestors were. Yet he stands before God and confesses as though he carried the guilt himself, identifying fully with his people. Daniel does precisely the same thing.

*I prayed to the Lord my God... while I was speaking and*

DANIEL 9:4, 20

**DANIEL, TOO, IS CONFESSING** the sins of his people rather than private failings, standing in the gap between what his people have done and what God's judgment will be. This is thoroughly biblical—and it is also antithetical to American individualism. We have been taught that sin is individual, that guilt is individual, that you answer only for your own actions; Scripture teaches something more complex, that you can bear corporate responsibility for systems you did not create but from which you benefit.

This does not mean white Americans alive today are personally guilty of slavery. It means that if you benefit from systems built through slavery, you carry a corporate responsibility to understand that history and to help dismantle the structures it still shapes. The Bible's ethical vision is simply larger than the individual conscience; it takes in the conscience of a people, the integrity of systems, the justice of structures.

Scripture even designs a mechanism for it, in one of the most subversively ignored passages in the law: the jubilee of Leviticus 25. Every fiftieth year the jubilee came, and all debts were forgiven, all enslaved people were freed, all land returned to its original owners, and the entire social structure reset. This was not charity, and it was not individual generosity; it was a structural intervention built into the law to prevent the permanent accumulation of wealth and power, because the Bible recognizes a hard truth—left to itself, the wealthy accumulate more wealth, the poor accumulate more debt, and you eventually produce a permanent underclass.

## WHAT THE BIBLE TEACHES, AND THE REAL SCANDAL

**GATHER THE THREADS, AND** the testimony of Scripture is consistent. Every person bears the divine image and cannot be reduced to a category or enslaved. Ethnicity is real and beautiful and will matter in the new creation. God cares about the systems and structures that oppress the vulnerable; the prophets read their societies structurally, not merely individually; corporate sin is real, and a people can bear responsibility for inherited injustice; and God himself designs structural mechanisms to prevent permanent oppression.

All of this is in Scripture. All of it sits comfortably with the reality that racism can be systemic, and all of it insists that

WHAT THE BIBLE ACTUALLY SAYS ABOUT RACE,  
ETHNICITY, AND THE IMAGE OF GOD

That is the real scandal. Not that CRT exists. That we needed CRT to wake us up to what our own Bible had been saying all along.

## CHAPTER 3

# The American Church's Racial History

*How American churches defended slavery, chose  
segregation, and stayed silent on civil rights*

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**YOU CANNOT UNDERSTAND THE** present crisis in the American church on race without first understanding what the church actually did across four hundred years—not what it said it believed, but what it did, and the theology it built to justify what it did. This will be painful to read if you are white. Good; it should be. It should also be clarifying if you are Black—a moment when someone finally says out loud what you already knew.

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*The history does not go away because  
we refuse to face it. It lives in the  
fabric of American Christianity.*

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**IN 1831, THORNTON STRINGFELLOW**, a Virginia Baptist minister, published "A Brief Examination of Scripture Testimony on the Institution of Slavery." Stringfellow was no fringe figure; he was a respected pastor and theologian, and his work became the standard biblical defense of slavery among Southern religious leaders. His argument ran like this: slavery appears throughout Scripture, God permitted it in the Old Testament, Jesus did not abolish it in the New—therefore slavery is not sinful, and to oppose it is to oppose Scripture.

He quoted the Levitical laws about slavery, pointed out that the patriarchs Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob owned slaves, and noted that Paul told slaves to obey their masters; if God had wanted to abolish slavery, Stringfellow reasoned, he would have done so explicitly, and since he did not, slavery must be consistent with God's design. But notice what he did not do. He did not engage the difference between indentured servitude in ancient Israel and the racial chattel slavery that defined America. He did not engage the texts about freeing slaves in the sabbath and jubilee years, nor the ethical vision of Exodus—God liberating enslaved people—nor the prophets' judgment against those who exploited the vulnerable. Stringfellow was selective. He was also effective, and his theology shaped Southern preaching for decades.

He was not alone. In 1856, James H. Thornwell, a Presbyterian theologian and president of South Carolina College, published a report on the religious instruction of enslaved people in which he argued that slavery was a "providential arrangement" of God, claiming the races had

These were not marginal voices but the major theological voices of the Southern church, and they shaped what evangelical churches believed about slavery. Nor was the failure confined to the South. Northern churches were complicit too; they grew rich on the back of slavery—financing slave ships, insuring slaving ventures, engaging in the triangle trade—and while they did not defend the institution theologically with the same vigor, they did nothing to stop it, facilitated it, and profited from it. The complicity was universal.

## THE CURSE OF HAM FROM SLAVERY TO SEGREGATION

**WE HAVE ALREADY LOOKED** at the curse of Ham, but it is worth seeing how systematically the American church weaponized it. Theologians and preachers took the brief text about Noah cursing Canaan and built an entire racial theology on it, arguing that all of Ham's descendants were cursed, mapping this onto the African peoples, and claiming the curse explained and justified slavery. This reading dominated the American pulpit for two hundred years. Children were raised hearing that God had cursed African peoples to slavery; ministers preached it,



The curse of Ham was so effective as a justification for slavery that when slavery ended, the curse lived on. If African peoples were cursed by God, then segregation was not a violation of God's design but obedience to it; if they were marked by God, then separate accommodations and separate schools and separate entrances were biblical. The curse of Ham became the theological foundation for two hundred years of American racism. It was completely made up. It had no basis in Scripture. But it was so effective that generations of Christians believed it. That history matters; it is in the bones of American Christianity, and if you do not know it, you do not understand why race is so intractable in American churches.

## **SLAVERY'S DEFENDERS AND THE PEOPLE WHO SAID NOTHING**

**THERE WERE CHRISTIANS WHO** opposed slavery. William Lloyd Garrison was a Christian abolitionist; Harriet Beecher Stowe was a Christian abolitionist; there were white abolitionists in the churches. But they were a minority, and they were opposed—Southern churches disfellowshipped them, Northern churches soft-pedaled their message, and mainline denominations split over slavery into North and South branches that did not reunite until the 1960s, some not even then.

The historical reality is hard but clear: the American church did not lead on abolition. It lagged. It fought against it. It provided theological cover for slavery long after the general culture had moved against it. This is not a minor thing; it is the defining failure of American Christianity. We had the

## SEGREGATION WAS A VOLUNTARY CHOICE, NOT FORCED BY LAW

**HERE IS A FACT** that often gets minimized: segregation in American churches was not primarily forced by law. It was chosen. After slavery ended, the Southern church could have chosen integration, because the law that required segregation in schools, public accommodations, and housing did not require it in churches. They did not integrate. They chose segregation—consciously, and on theological grounds. The theology of segregation held that God made the races different and intended them to remain separate, that integration was against God's design, and that the church should model the separation God intended.

Baptist, Methodist, Pentecostal, and Holiness churches alike chose segregation. Some established "colored" churches as a supposedly benevolent way to let Black people worship in their own way, but those churches received a fraction of the resources and remained under white denominational control; the benevolence masked the hierarchy. Black churches themselves were created partly by necessity and partly by choice—a choice to have control over their own spiritual lives, free from white domination—and the Black church tradition became one of the most spiritually vital in American Christianity. But it was forged against the backdrop of white churches choosing separation.

## BILLY GRAHAM'S COMPLICATED LEGACY ON RACE

**BILLY GRAHAM IS OFTEN** held up as an example of evangelical progress on race, and he did some things right. In the 1950s, when it was genuinely countercultural, Graham desegregated some of his crusades and invited Black pastors to participate in his events; he did not make a large public stand on civil rights, but he moved in the right direction. He also preached to segregated audiences, held crusades in the South where Black people had to sit in separate sections, and declined to use his massive platform to prophetically confront segregation, preaching the gospel in a way that left the systems unchallenged.

Graham was better than most. He was also not good enough—a transitional figure who pointed the direction the church should have gone without fully going there. What makes his legacy complicated is the use later made of it: evangelicals have pointed to Graham's minimal steps toward integration to claim that evangelicalism was actually progressive on race, using a good man's partial steps as cover for our own inaction while most evangelicals remained segregated. Not honesty. Self-justification.

**THE CIVIL RIGHTS MOVEMENT** of the 1960s was, in many ways, a Christian movement. Martin Luther King was a pastor; John Lewis was a minister; James Lawson was an ordained elder; the movement was rooted in theology, in the prophetic tradition, in the Exodus story. So where were the evangelicals? Largely silent. Evangelical churches did not march and evangelical leaders did not speak; some churches actively resisted integration, some pastors called civil rights a communist plot, and some theologians argued that race relations were a matter for individual conscience rather than something for churches or government to address.

The historical record is clear that evangelicalism was, by and large, on the wrong side of the civil rights movement. There were exceptions—John Perkins committed his life to racial reconciliation, some evangelical churches integrated, and some leaders supported the movement quietly even when they would not do so publicly. But the institutional evangelical church, the denominations and the major churches and the theological voices, was silent or opposed during the moral moment of the twentieth century.

That silence had consequences. It signaled to Black Christians that evangelicalism was not their home, that evangelical Christianity was comfortable with white supremacy, and it opened a breach between Black and white evangelicalism that never fully healed. Black evangelicals exist, but evangelicalism as a whole is experienced by Black Christians as a white religion. That is not accident. That is history.

**WE ARE NOW IN** a moment where the American church is being confronted with this history. Some churches are trying to reckon with it; some are ignoring it; some are saying the reckoning itself is the problem. But the history does not go away because we refuse to face it. It lives in the fabric of American Christianity—in predominantly white churches in neighborhoods that were redlined, in church leadership structures where Black voices are absent, in theological grids shaped by centuries of racial hierarchy.

The question is not whether the American church has a racial history; the question is what the American church will do with it. Will we face it, confess it, repent of it in ways that actually cost us something—or will we pretend it was a different era, a different church, not our responsibility? The prophetic tradition is unsparing here: you cannot move forward while carrying a lie, you cannot be reconciled while denying what you did, and you cannot claim the gospel while maintaining systems built on injustice.

The American church built systems on injustice. It defended slavery. It chose segregation. It remained silent during the fight for civil rights. That history is not behind us. It is in us. The question is what we will do with it.

## CHAPTER 4

# Martin Luther King's Theology

*The radical theology behind the dream – and what  
the white church has tried to forget*

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**MARTIN LUTHER KING JR.** is quoted in nearly every American church during Black History Month. His "I Have a Dream" speech is celebrated, his name invoked, his image printed into Sunday school materials; the mainstream evangelical church now honors him without hesitation. But honoring a man and reading him are not the same thing. Almost no white evangelical church has actually sat with what King wrote and said, and if it had, it would have to confront an uncomfortable fact: King was far more demanding than contemporary evangelicalism is willing to be.

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*He was not asking the church to do  
diversity training. He was asking it to*

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**KING WAS NOT ASKING** the church for diversity training, and he was not asking for representation in its leadership. He was asking for something far more searching — that the American church actually believe the gospel it claimed to believe, and live as if that belief carried a cost.

### **THE LETTER FROM BIRMINGHAM JAIL AND THE WHITE MODERATE**

**IN APRIL 1963, KING** was arrested in Birmingham, Alabama, for leading protests against segregation, and from that cell he wrote what would become his most important theological document, the "Letter from Birmingham Jail." The letter was addressed to a group of white clergy who had published a statement calling King's actions "unwise and untimely." These clergy were not defending segregation; they were asking King to slow down, to wait for the right time, to work within the system, to be patient. His response was theologically devastating.

*I must confess that I am not afraid of the word 'tension' in this connection. I have earnestly opposed violent tension, but there is a type of constructive, nonviolent tension which is necessary for growth.*

LETTER FROM BIRMINGHAM JAIL

the request for patience really was. You are asking me to stop creating tension about injustice, he was saying; you want me to keep the peace — but the peace you want is the peace of injustice left undisturbed, and that is not peace at all. That is complicity. Then he wrote the line that should still arrest every white Christian who has ever preached about social order.

*I must make two honest confessions to you, my Christian and Jewish brothers. First, I must confess that over the past few years I have been gravely disappointed with the white moderate. I have almost reached the regrettable conclusion that the Negro's great stumbling block in his stride toward freedom is not the White Citizen's Counciler or the Ku Klux Klansman, but the white moderate, who is more devoted to 'order' than to justice.*

LETTER FROM BIRMINGHAM JAIL

**THIS IS THE THING** white Christianity has never quite forgiven King for saying. Not that white racists were bad — of course they were. But that the white moderate, the person who claimed to believe in equality yet would not act, who valued order more than justice, was the greater obstacle to freedom. The white moderate is the pastor who says he believes in civil rights but worries about offending people; the church leader who supports equality but not now, not like this; the Christian who agrees that segregation is wrong while continuing to benefit from it. King named the moderate as the problem precisely because the moderate held just enough legitimacy to slow justice down — the one always



Then King went further, refusing the comforting idea that the passage of time would, on its own, do the work of justice.

*Actually, time itself is neutral... There is 'time for all things.' It is often said that time will tell. Actually, time is always on the side of the oppressor, not on the side of the justice-seeker.*

LETTER FROM BIRMINGHAM JAIL

**WAITING, PATIENCE, SLOW AND** deliberate process — these all quietly favor the people already in power. The longer justice is deferred, the more time the powerful have to organize against it, and the people being harmed are the ones who cannot afford to wait.

## **KING ON UNJUST LAW AND THE HIGHER LAW OF GOD**

**FROM THERE KING BROUGHT** down the theological hammer, reaching for the hardest possible comparison to make his point about law and conscience.

*We should never forget that everything Adolf Hitler did in Germany was 'legal.' It was illegal to aid and comfort a Jew in Hitler's Germany. But I would have aided and comforted my Jewish brothers.*

LETTER FROM BIRMINGHAM JAIL

**KING WAS SETTING SEGREGATION** law beside Nazi law to make a single claim: the law is not the same thing as justice. An unjust law is not binding on the conscience, because there is a higher law than the law of man, and

## BEYOND THE DREAM: KING'S RADICAL CRITIQUE OF THE SYSTEM

**MOST PEOPLE KNOW KING'S** theology from a single source, the "I Have a Dream" speech. The speech is beautiful and hopeful; it imagines a day when people will be "judged not by the color of their skin but by the content of their character." But if that is all you have read of King, you do not yet know his theology. The Dream is one moment inside a much larger and more searching body of work.

Read his sermons "Why Jesus Called a Man a Fool" and "A Knock at Midnight"; read his book "Where Do We Go from Here: Chaos or Community?" In these texts King is prophetic and unsettling, not merely calling for integration but for a fundamental restructuring of American economic and political life. In "Where Do We Go from Here," he turns directly to the problem of poverty.

*Something is wrong with capitalism... the profit motive alone is not adequate to meet the needs of every member of the society... true compassion is more than flinging a coin to a beggar; it comes to see that an edifice which produces beggars needs restructuring.*

**WHERE DO WE GO FROM HERE: CHAOS OR COMMUNITY?**

for minor reforms to soften poverty's edges. He was arguing that the system producing the poverty needed to be restructured at its core — that the foundation itself was wrong. He was equally critical of militarism; in his 1967 sermon "Beyond Vietnam" he said America needed a subversive reordering of its priorities, its foreign policy, its commitment to war. And he was clear about what he was prepared to die for. In his final sermon, delivered the night before his assassination, he said, "Well, I don't know what will happen now. We've got some difficult days ahead. But it doesn't matter with me now." He was not afraid, and he was not hedging. He was willing to die for justice.

## KING'S ESCHATOLOGY AND THE ARC OF JUSTICE

**PART OF WHAT MADE** King powerful was his eschatological conviction — his belief that God had already decided the outcome of history, that the arc of history bent toward justice, and that God's kingdom would come whether America cooperated or not. This is easy to miss. King was not optimistic about American progress, and he was not trusting in human ingenuity or American goodness. He was trusting in God. His confidence rested on the conviction that God had already settled the matter, and that his own work was simply to align himself with what God was already doing.

This is, in large measure, the faith the contemporary American church has lost. We have become pragmatists who calculate what is possible and work within existing systems, no longer believing that God might be asking us to do

## HOW EVANGELICALISM DOMESTICATED KING

**EVANGELICAL CHRISTIANITY HAS ADOPTED** King's name while quietly setting aside his theology. We quote the dream and ignore his critique of capitalism; we celebrate his nonviolence while maintaining our own structures of advantage and exploitation; we have turned a revolutionary into a safe figure, a man of the past who said agreeable things about equality. If the church had actually listened to him, it would have had to ask itself hard questions: whether its churches benefit from unjust economic systems, whether it loves order more than justice, whether it asks oppressed people to wait, whether it is more devoted to comfort than to prophetic witness, and what systems in our own moment we defend when we should be resisting. Those questions have gone mostly unasked. We have quoted King's dream while maintaining our nightmares.

His real challenge to white Christianity comes as a series of professed beliefs held up against a way of life. You say you believe the gospel. You say all people are made in God's image, that Jesus broke down the wall between Jew and Gentile, that the cross has power to reconcile enemies. But

The American church owes King something, beginning with the acknowledgment that he was right and we were wrong — that we were silent, that we were comfortable, that we chose order over justice, that we remained in segregated churches and theological institutions and leadership structures while he was jailed and beaten for calling us to believe what we claimed to believe. We owe him the work of reading him honestly: not the sanitized King of Black History Month, but the real one — the man killed because he threatened too much, who called American capitalism, American militarism, and American Christianity to account. And we owe him one more question. If he were alive today, what would he be calling the contemporary church to account for — which systems, which marginalized people, which theology built to justify the unjust? That is the real work of honoring him. Not quoting him. Hearing him — actually hearing what he said, and actually changing in response.

## CHAPTER 5

# Is Systemic Racism Real?

*What Scripture teaches about corporate sin, and what  
the evidence shows about systems*

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### THE BIBLICAL CASE FOR CORPORATE SIN: NEHEMIAH, DANIEL, ACHAN

**THE MOST COMMON CONSERVATIVE** argument against understanding racism as systemic runs in a clean line: the Bible teaches that sin is individual; only individuals sin, only individuals can repent; therefore we cannot speak of systemic racism, only of individual racists. The logic is tidy, and it is wrong. It is a modern individualism read backward into Scripture, because the Bible carries a strong and sustained theology of corporate sin.

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*A people can be responsible for the*

**CONSIDER NEHEMIAH. THE REBUILT** Jerusalem is struggling; Ezra the scribe reads the law aloud, and as the people hear it they begin to see how far they have strayed from it. They gather to pray, and Nehemiah leads them in confession. Listen to what he confesses.

*We have acted very wickedly toward you. We have not obeyed the commands, decrees and laws you gave your servant Moses.*

NEHEMIAH 1:7

**LATER, IN CHAPTER 9,** the confession grows more elaborate: "They were disobedient and rebelled against you; they put your law behind their backs. They killed your prophets, who had admonished them in order to turn them back to you." Here is the crucial thing. Nehemiah is confessing sins committed by his ancestors. He was not alive when they broke the law; he did not personally kill the prophets. Yet he confesses these sins as though he had committed them himself.

Why? Because he understands that sin is not merely individual; it has a corporate dimension. A people can be responsible for the systems and patterns their ancestors created, and a person can inherit guilt for continuing them. Nor is this an isolated case. When Achan sinned in Joshua 7, Israel executed not only Achan but his entire household; the sin of one man implicated his whole family, and the judgment fell on the corporate entity, not the individual alone.

Daniel makes the point even clearer. Daniel is a righteous

*I prayed to the Lord my God and confessed: 'O Lord, the great and dreadful God, who keeps his covenant of love with all who love him and obey his commands, we have sinned and done wrong. We have been wicked and have rebelled; we have turned away from your commands and laws. We have not listened to your servants the prophets.'*

DANIEL 9:4-6

**DANIEL FOLDS HIMSELF INTO** a collective guilt for sins he did not commit. He stands with his people in their sin and confesses on behalf of the nation, because he grasps that nations and peoples have a corporate existence; the sins of the nation are the sins of its people, not individually but collectively. This is no marginal teaching. It runs through the whole of Scripture. Joshua confesses Israel's sins. Jeremiah speaks for Israel. Nehemiah identifies with Israel's sin. The pattern is consistent.

## CORPORATE RESPONSIBILITY IN THE PROPHETS

**THE PROPHETS ARE CLEARER** still about corporate responsibility, and they aim their indictments not at scattered offenders but at the structure itself. Amos speaks to the nation as a whole.

*They sell the innocent for silver, and the needy for a pair of sandals.*

AMOS 2:6



out a handful of individual evil-doers who happened to sell innocent people; he is naming a system. The nation of Israel, as a corporate entity, was complicit in the practice. Isaiah presses the same charge against the laws themselves.

*Woe to those who make unjust laws, to those who issue  
oppressive decrees, to deprive the poor of their rights...  
What will you do on the day of reckoning?*

ISAIAH 10:1-3

**ISAIAH IS NOT MERELY** condemning individual wicked lawmakers; he is condemning the structure, the laws themselves, which are unjust even though they were enacted through legitimate legal processes. The nation that wrote them bears the guilt. Micah turns the indictment toward the leaders.

*Hear, you leaders of Jacob, you rulers of Israel... You eat  
the flesh of my people and tear away their skin.*

MICAH 3:1-3

**MICAH NAMES STRUCTURAL VIOLENCE.** The leaders, the corporate power structure, are consuming the people, not one by one but as a system.

## THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN INDIVIDUAL AND SYSTEMIC SIN

**HERE IS WHAT NEEDS** to be clear: naming systemic sin does not erase individual responsibility. An individual racist is still individually guilty. An individual who benefits from unjust systems while doing nothing to change them is still individually guilty. But systemic sin is

Take a concrete case. A bank has lending criteria that look neutral on their face, asking only for credit history, income, and collateral, with nothing explicitly about race. But if those criteria systematically deny loans to Black applicants at rates significantly higher than white applicants, then the system is racist regardless of whether the loan officer harbors any racial animus. Is the loan officer individually guilty of racism? Perhaps not; he may be personally colorblind. He is, even so, participating in a system that perpetuates racism, and that system is real.

The prophets saw both levels at once. They condemned the oppressor, the individual who actively exploited the poor, and they condemned the system that enabled the oppression, recognizing that a society can run an entire machinery of injustice even when most of the people inside it do not think of themselves as unjust.

### **THE EVIDENCE: HOUSING, CRIMINAL JUSTICE, EMPLOYMENT, EDUCATION**

**BY NOW THIS IS** not a theoretical question but an empirical one, and the evidence is overwhelming. Begin with housing. The Federal Housing Administration explicitly refused to insure mortgages in neighborhoods with Black residents; this was federal policy, and the FHA literally drew maps marking as "hazardous" any neighborhood that included Black residents. Black families could not access government-backed mortgages

Criminal justice tells the same story. Black people receive longer sentences than white people for identical crimes, and the data are consistent: a Black man convicted of a felony receives a sentence on average twenty percent longer than a white man convicted of the same felony. Are individual judges consciously racist? Some may be. But the pattern is systemic; it is simply how the system operates.

Employment shows it in controlled experiments. When researchers send out identical resumes, one bearing a "white-sounding" name and one a "Black-sounding" name, the resume with the white-sounding name consistently draws more callbacks. Same qualifications, same resume, different name, different outcome. Education shows it in the budgets. Schools in predominantly Black neighborhoods receive significantly less funding than schools in predominantly white neighborhoods, even within the same district; the facilities are worse and the teachers less experienced, and this is not an accident but a feature of how the system is structured.

Policing shows it in the gravest terms. Black people are killed by police at a rate three times higher than white people even after adjusting for crime rates, and they are more likely to be stopped, searched, and arrested for the same behaviors that white people engage in with impunity. These are not individual racist acts. These are patterns. This is how systems work, and the Bible would call it structural sin: a system operating in a way that produces racial injustice, a system

## WHERE CONSERVATIVES GET CONFUSED – AND THE CALL TO CORPORATE REPENTANCE

**CONSERVATIVE CHRISTIANITY OFTEN OBJECTS** that systemic racism implies individual white people are guilty simply for being white. That is not what the term means. Systemic racism means that systems are structured in ways that benefit white people and harm Black people, so that individual white people benefit from those systems whether or not they ever consciously chose to.

An analogy helps. If you inherit a house built on stolen land, you are benefiting from an injustice you did not personally commit; you did not steal the land, but you are living in the house. That does not make you guilty of theft. It does mean you carry a responsibility to understand that your house stands on injustice, and to weigh what you owe to the people whose land was taken. Individual white people are not guilty of slavery. We did not enslave anyone. But we benefit from systems built through slavery, maintained through segregation, and still operating in ways that privilege white people and disadvantage Black people. That is not guilt. That is reality.

If corporate sin is real, and Scripture teaches that it is, then corporate repentance must be real too. A nation can repent. A people can repent. A system can be repented of and changed. Nehemiah modeled exactly this. He did not say, "I am not personally guilty, so I will not confess." He confessed on behalf of his people, identified with their sin, and led them

So the summary holds. Systemic racism is real. Scripture affirms that systems can be unjust, that corporate bodies can be responsible for injustice, and that repentance of systemic injustice is possible. The American church needs to acknowledge that American Christian systems benefited from slavery and segregation; to confess that the church defended these systems theologically; to recognize that many contemporary systems still carry the weight of that history; and to commit to changing those systems in ways that cost something. Not as individuals claiming personal innocence. As a people confessing corporate sin and committing to corporate transformation. That is what Nehemiah did. That is what Daniel did. That is what the prophets called for. The question is whether the American church will do it.

## CHAPTER 6

# Where CRT Gets It Right

*The observations about American systems that  
Scripture also makes*

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**CRITICAL RACE THEORY IS** not the gospel; it cannot transform a human heart, and it does not offer reconciliation. But on one narrower question it deserves a careful hearing: some of what its scholars observe about how American systems function is accurate, and several of those observations are ones the Bible makes too. A Christian can disagree with CRT's ultimate solutions while acknowledging where its diagnosis is correct. That is not capitulation. That is honesty.

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*A Christian can disagree with CRT's  
ultimate solutions while  
acknowledging where its diagnosis is  
correct.*

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**CRT SCHOLARS OBSERVE THAT** institutions—law, education, economics, criminal justice—are not neutral; they were built by people in power, built to serve people in power, and they continue to serve people in power. This is not a subversive claim but a reading of the historical record. American law was written by men, and it protected male property rights and male political power. That is not judgment. That is history.

The pattern repeats across the institutions that shaped American life. American criminal law was written by people who benefited from slavery, and the Thirteenth Amendment abolished slavery except as punishment for crime—a clause that left the law open as an instrument of racial control, which it has been ever since. American housing policy was written by people who set out to segregate the country by race; the FHA's redlining was not accidental but deliberate policy, designed to keep Black families out of white neighborhoods.

Look at the history of these institutions, CRT scholars say, and you will see that they were designed by people in power to serve people in power; even where the language has since changed, the function remains. This is correct. You can read the record, trace how the institutions were built, and follow the continuities from the past into the present.

The Bible teaches something similar. The prophets looked at the institutions of their time and asked who benefits and who is harmed. When Amos looked at the law courts of Israel, he saw that the poor could not get justice—the law was tilted toward the wealthy. When Isaiah looked at the kings of Israel,

## LIVED EXPERIENCE AS A SOURCE OF KNOWLEDGE

**CRT SCHOLARS HOLD THAT** people who have experienced injustice carry legitimate knowledge about how injustice works. A Black person stopped by police again and again knows something that data collection cannot fully capture; a person denied a mortgage knows something about housing discrimination that statistics do not convey. This, too, is biblical. The psalms are full of people crying out because they have suffered injustice, and God calls his people to listen.

*Defend the weak and the fatherless; uphold the cause of the poor and the oppressed.*

PSALM 82:3

**HOW DO YOU COME** to know the cause of the poor and the oppressed? By listening to them, by treating their testimony as a primary source of knowledge. Proverbs makes the same point about the limits of a single account:

*The first to speak in court seems right, until someone comes forward and questions him.*

PROVERBS 18:15

**YOU DO NOT FULLY** understand an issue until you have heard from the people it affects. A man who has never



Here the American church has failed. White churches have made decisions about race without adequately listening to Black Christians; white pastors have preached about racial justice without consulting Black pastors; white theologians have written about race without engaging Black theological traditions. CRT is simply saying: listen to the people who have experienced the injustice you are trying to address. That is also what Scripture says.

### **INTEREST CONVERGENCE: WHEN MAJORITY GROUPS CHOOSE CHANGE**

**DERRICK BELL MADE AN** observation he called interest convergence. He looked at *Brown v. Board of Education*, the Supreme Court decision that declared school segregation unconstitutional—on its face a clear victory for racial justice, the Court announcing that segregation is wrong. But Bell noticed the timing: *Brown* came down precisely when America needed to project an image of racial progress to the world. In the Cold War the country was competing with the Soviet Union for global influence, Soviet propaganda kept pointing to American segregation, and America needed to show the world it was moving

Brown arrived at the moment when ending segregation served America's interests in that global contest. Bell's insight follows from this: progress on race happens not only because justice demands it, but because it serves the interests of the majority group. Cynical? Perhaps. It is also historically accurate. Emancipation came after a brutal war. The Thirteenth Amendment passed once the North held military victory. The Civil Rights Act passed when the country had been shaken by the assassination of Kennedy and the moral force of the civil rights movement had made silence impossible.

Progress happens when justice serves the interest of the majority group; before that moment the majority resists, and after the moment passes it often tries to reverse what was won. American religious life shows the pattern plainly. The church integrated somewhat during the civil rights era, when the nation was integrating and integration seemed inevitable—but as soon as it became inconvenient, as soon as white flight became possible and charter schools became available, the church re-segregated.

The church did not change its theology about race; its behavior changed because the circumstances changed. The interest convergence ended, and the church returned to segregation. This is not a verdict that people are evil. It is an observation about how systems work: they change when the people in power find it advantageous, and they persist when they keep benefiting the people in power. CRT scholars are making a sociological observation, and the Bible makes a similar one, noting that the wealthy resist justice because justice threatens their wealth.

AMOS 5:10

**THE WEALTHY RESIST JUSTICE.** That is what CRT scholars observe, and what the Bible also teaches.

**NAMING PATTERNS WITHOUT NAMING VILLAINS**

**ONE OF CRT'S REAL** strengths is that it lets you name a pattern without requiring that every person caught in the pattern be a conscious villain. A white banker in 2026 is not defending slavery; the banker is probably a decent person. But the banker operates within a system that still carries the weight of centuries of racial exclusion from wealth-building—the banker is part of a pattern. Naming that pattern is not accusing the banker of being racist. It is observing that the system the banker works within perpetuates racial inequity.

This distinction matters because it lets white people have honest conversations about race without having to defend their own virtue. You do not have to argue that you are not racist; you can simply acknowledge that the systems you benefit from have racial histories and continue to produce racial outcomes, and then ask what you should do about that.

The Bible teaches the same distinction, because God judges nations and systems, not only individuals. When God says through Amos, "For three sins of Israel... I will not turn back my wrath," he is not declaring every individual Israelite evil; he is saying the nation as a whole has sinned, that the system operates unjustly. An individual can acknowledge corporate sin without personalizing it as an attack on his own

## THE LIMITS OF CRT FOR A CHRISTIAN VISION

**HAVING SAID WHERE CRT** is right, let me be equally clear about where its structure has limits that Christianity must transcend. CRT sees human beings primarily as situated within relationships of power: you are what you are because of where you sit in the system, oppressed or oppressor, and that position becomes your essence. Christianity sees human beings primarily as image-bearers. That is your essence. Your status as oppressed or oppressor is real, but it is not who you are. You are God's beloved, and that is where your identity comes from.

The difference shapes what each vision believes is possible. If a person's essence is defined by position in a power system, then changing the system might change the position but not the essence. But if a person's essence is being God's beloved, then transformation is possible—a person can move from being shaped by injustice to being shaped by God's love. This is the gospel's promise. This is what CRT cannot offer.

So the account can be stated plainly. CRT scholars are observing real things about American systems: that systems are not neutral but were designed by people in power and continue to serve them; that the lived experience of marginalized people is a source of knowledge; that systems change when the interests of the majority group align with the change; and that you can name patterns without requiring that every person in the pattern be consciously evil. All of these observations are consistent with Scripture. The

The church does not need to choose between naming injustice and offering transformation. It needs to do both, because the prophets did both and Jesus did both; he named the hypocrisy of the religious system and offered forgiveness to the woman caught in sin. CRT can help us see the systems more clearly. The gospel can help us transform them.

## CHAPTER 7

# Where CRT Gets It Wrong

*Where critical race theory collides with the gospel's  
view of the human person*

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*Christianity's ultimate concern is not  
power. It is wholeness, healing,  
reconciliation.*

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### THE ANTHROPOLOGICAL PROBLEM: IDENTITY IN CRT VS. THE IMAGE OF GOD

**CRITICAL RACE THEORY GETS** some things right about American systems, as the previous chapter granted at length. But its ultimate structure contradicts Christian

In CRT's account, human identity is understood primarily through position in a system of power. Who you are is determined by what group you belong to and what power relationships that group holds; identity is group-based and power-based. Christianity teaches something radically different. A human being is first a creature made in God's image, loved by God, redeemed by God. That is your identity, more foundational than your race, your gender, your class, or your status as oppressor or oppressed. Your identity is being God's beloved.

This is not a semantic quibble. It is foundational, and it changes everything about how you understand yourself and how you engage the people around you. If identity is primarily power-based, then the goal of justice becomes the inversion of the power relationship: the oppressed should become the oppressors, the marginalized should become the centered, and justice reduces to the question of who gets to be in power. If identity is rooted instead in being God's beloved, then the goal of justice is not to invert hierarchies but to eliminate them — to build a community where no one stands in power over anyone else, where everyone is equally beloved, where everyone serves everyone else. These are not the same thing.

## **THE PROBLEM OF GUILT WITHOUT REDEMPTION**

as a structure for justice is that it often embeds unforgiveness into the system itself. If a person's identity is determined by their oppressor status, then that person cannot be healed of that identity; they remain locked in relationship with the system that damaged them. Christianity offers something different. It offers forgiveness — not forgetting, not pretending the harm did not happen, but the genuine possibility of moving beyond the harm that was done. In the CRT structure, a person who has been harmed carries that harm as part of their identity. In the Christian structure, a person can be healed of that harm and move forward, freed from the identity of victim.

None of this is to say that acknowledging harm is unhealthy; acknowledging harm is necessary. But being defined by harm is not freedom. Being defined by harm is remaining in bondage to it. Jesus offers another way. "For freedom Christ has set us free; stand firm therefore, and do not submit again to a yoke of slavery."

*For freedom Christ has set us free; stand firm therefore,  
and do not submit again to a yoke of slavery.*

GALATIANS 5:1

**THAT VERSE IS OFTEN** quoted in individual contexts — freedom from sin, freedom from guilt. But it applies to systems too. You do not have to remain in the identity the system tried to hand you; you can be freed from it. The same problem runs the other direction. CRT often leaves white people with guilt but no path to redemption. You have benefited from unjust systems — true. You carry the benefit of centuries of injustice — true. But now what? CRT



In a structure where identity is fixed by oppressor status, a white person is locked in that status, unable to escape being an oppressor because that is what the system has made them. Christianity offers forgiveness instead — genuine forgiveness, not getting off the hook, not pretending the harm didn't happen, but real forgiveness that opens the possibility of being freed from the guilt. This matters because without the possibility of forgiveness, reconciliation is impossible. If a person is locked in guilt with no way out, they cannot genuinely meet the other person; they can only meet them as someone trapped in their own shame.

## **CRT AND THE MISSING PIECE OF RECONCILIATION**

**CRT IS CONCERNED WITH** justice, and justice is important. But CRT often settles for justice without reconciliation. It can name the perpetrator and demand restitution; it can change systems and redistribute power. Where it struggles is the question of what happens after justice: can the perpetrator and the victim actually become one people again? Christianity insists on reconciliation — not at the expense of justice, for justice must come first, but as the goal, so that people who have been enemies can become family again.

Consider Philemon, a short letter in the Bible. Paul writes to Philemon about Onesimus, a slave who ran away from

Paul is not asking Philemon to do nothing about the injustice of slavery. He is asking for more than justice. He is asking for love — for the possibility that these two people might actually become family. This is what Christianity offers that CRT does not: the possibility that people who have been divided can actually be reconciled. There is a deeper missing piece as well. CRT's structure assumes that systems are the problem and that changing systems is the solution; redistribute power, change laws, embed justice in structures, and you have solved the problem. But systems are not the only problem. People are. People carry sin, people carry brokenness, and people — even inside just systems — can still choose injustice.

The gospel offers the transformation of people, not just systems. It says you can be made new. "Therefore, if anyone is in Christ, the new creation has come: The old has gone, the new is here!"

*Therefore, if anyone is in Christ, the new creation has come: The old has gone, the new is here!*

2 CORINTHIANS 5:17

thinking, and it is not ignoring systems. It is the claim that human hearts can actually change — that people can repent, that people can turn from injustice. CRT does not have tools for this. It can identify who is responsible for systemic injustice, but it cannot offer the power to repent and change.

## WHEN JUSTICE WITHOUT RECONCILIATION FAILS

**HISTORY OFFERS EXAMPLES OF** justice pursued without reconciliation. After World War I, the Treaty of Versailles imposed terms so harsh that the German people felt humiliated and hungry for revenge; they wanted to overturn the terms, convinced that what was called justice was not justice at all but oppression. The result was resentment that festered and helped clear the road for the rise of Hitler. After the Rwanda genocide, the country could have chosen simple retribution — the perpetrators could have been killed. Instead Rwanda chose Truth and Reconciliation: perpetrators admitted what they had done, victims heard the admissions, and communities worked toward healing. It was not simple and it was not easy, but it opened the possibility of people actually living together again.

The pattern is clear enough to state as a verdict. Justice without reconciliation breeds resentment; justice with reconciliation opens the possibility of actually healing the breach. That is the difference between a settlement that festers and a settlement that holds.

## WHERE CONTEMPORARY CRT

**TO BE CLEAR, I** am not saying CRT is evil. CRT is a tool. It can help you see systems more clearly and name what you might not have named before; for a Christian, it can be a useful ally in naming systemic sin. But it cannot be your structure for understanding justice, because its ultimate concern is power — who has it, who doesn't, how to redistribute it. Christianity's ultimate concern is not power. It is wholeness. It is healing. It is reconciliation. A Christian should be able to say: I see what CRT names about systems, and that is real; I also see what Christianity offers beyond that, and that is more real; I am committed both to naming injustice and to offering transformation; I am committed both to justice and to reconciliation; I believe that systems should change and that people should be made new. That is not compromising the gospel. That is fulfilling the gospel.

In its most extreme contemporary applications, CRT becomes something other than what its original scholars intended. In some applications it comes to mean viewing all white people as inherently oppressive regardless of their actions, viewing all Black people as inherently victims regardless of their agency, refusing to recognize that individuals have choices within systems, making identity categories absolute and untraversable, and offering no hope for genuine reconciliation or transformation. These applications have moved away from CRT as an academic analysis toward something closer to ideology. And ideology — whether it comes from the left or the right — is dangerous in the church. The gospel is not ideology. The gospel is the story of God's redemption, and it transcends any human system of

So a Christian can engage CRT critically: learning from it what is true while rejecting what contradicts the gospel, naming systemic injustice while offering hope for systemic transformation and personal redemption. That posture requires holding several things in tension at once. Systems are real, and unjust systems must be named and changed. People are real, and people can be transformed and redeemed. Justice must happen, and reconciliation is the goal. Power structures should be flattened, and all people are equally beloved. These are not contradictions. They are the fuller vision of what the gospel offers compared to what any secular structure can offer.

## CHAPTER 8

# White Evangelicalism's Blind Spot

*Why the loudest critics of CRT have not reckoned with  
their own racial history*

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*You cannot credibly critique a theory  
that names racial systems while  
maintaining the very systems it is  
trying to name.*

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## THE SOUTHERN BAPTIST CONVENTION'S FOUNDING TO DEFEND SLAVERY

**THERE IS AN IRONY** in the current debate that should not be missed. The loudest voices attacking Critical Race

Consider the founding facts. The Southern Baptist Convention was founded in 1845, and it was founded to defend slavery. Before that year Baptists in America operated within a single denomination, the American Baptists, but tensions over slavery were rising; Northern Baptists had begun moving toward abolition while Southern Baptists remained committed to the institution, and the Convention was created specifically to allow Southern Baptists to maintain and defend it. This is not interpretation. This is history. The Convention was literally formed as a religious defense of slavery.

For the next 120 years the SBC defended slavery, then defended segregation, then resisted integration with vigor; it did not integrate its seminaries until the 1980s, and it elected its first non-white denomination-wide leader only recently, many decades after the civil rights era. In recent years the SBC has officially apologized for its stance on slavery and segregation, and that apology is genuinely good — but an apology is not the same as fundamental change. Its leadership structure remains overwhelmingly white, and the wealth gap between white and Black Baptist communities

## THE EVANGELICAL REALIGNMENT AND THE SEGREGATION ACADEMIES

**AFTER BROWN V. BOARD** of Education declared segregation unconstitutional in 1954, white evangelicals faced a choice. They could accept integration, they could lead on racial justice, they could say that the gospel compels a movement toward reconciliation. They did not. Instead, white evangelicals built a massive network of segregation academies — private schools designed specifically to allow white children to avoid integrated public schools.

These were not fringe institutions. They were mainline evangelical ones: Bob Jones University, Oral Roberts University, hundreds of Christian schools founded for the explicit purpose of maintaining separation. Not integration academies. Not schools designed to offer Christian education while modeling reconciliation. Segregation academies, whose stated purpose was to let white families keep their children racially separate. Many of them maintained explicit rules against interracial dating into the 1980s and 1990s; Bob Jones University did not remove its ban on interracial dating



This is the history of white evangelicalism, and it implicates the tradition I am writing from. We created a vast infrastructure to maintain racial separation in the name of Christian education — and we did it not in the 1920s but in the 1950s and 1960s, in the very moment the nation was beginning to integrate.

## THE RELIGIOUS RIGHT'S REAL ORIGIN

**THE CONTEMPORARY RELIGIOUS RIGHT** is often credited with beginning around abortion: the standard account holds that evangelicals, alarmed by *Roe v. Wade* in 1973, mobilized into politics. That account is wrong. The religious right began around segregation. It was mobilized to defend the segregation academies and to preserve racial separation.

In 1981 Jerry Falwell declared, "The time has come to call our nation back to God, back to morality, back to sensibility, and back to conservatism." His moment of calling the nation back was happening precisely as the segregation academies came under legal threat for their discriminatory policies. Falwell was defending segregation. That was the origin. Abortion came later and became the public face, but segregation was the root. This matters because it means white evangelicalism's entry into politics was built on the defense of racial separation; the religious right was birthed as a resistance movement to integration. Once you know that history, the present comes into focus — when white evangelicals attack CRT today, what you are watching is a tradition defending its own racial systems while attacking the system that names them.

**HERE IS WHAT MAKES** the attack on CRT from white evangelical pulpits ring hollow. CRT is attempting to name how systems perpetuate racial injustice; it argues that institutions embed bias in ways that are not always visible, and that people can benefit from unjust systems without being consciously malicious. That description, set beside the record, is uncomfortably close to a self-portrait. White evangelicalism benefited from unjust racial systems. It created and maintained the segregation academies. It remains overwhelmingly white in its leadership. It built much of its wealth and influence on racial separation and racial hierarchy. CRT is naming the very thing white evangelicalism has done.

So when white evangelical leaders attack CRT, the message underneath the argument often amounts to this: do not name the systems we benefit from, do not point out how our institutions perpetuate racial hierarchy, do not force us to reckon with our history. Whatever else it is, that is not, at bottom, intellectual critique. It is institutional self-protection.

There is an intellectual dishonesty here as well. The loudest evangelical attacks on CRT tend to come from people who have made no serious attempt to understand it; they have not read Derrick Bell, they have not read Kimberlé Crenshaw, and they are attacking a caricature rather than the argument. If you are going to critique CRT, you should at least know what CRT says — you should be able to quote it accurately and engage what it actually claims, and most evangelical attacks fail that basic test. More than that, if you critique CRT while maintaining your own unjust systems, you

There is also the matter of selective memory. Many white evangelicals know about Billy Graham's modest steps toward integration, and many can point to individual evangelical leaders who opposed racism; but many do not know about the segregation academies, do not know that the religious right was founded to defend segregation, do not know that SBC seminaries were segregated into the 1980s. That selective memory lets white evangelicals feel progressive on race while maintaining systems that perpetuate injustice — they can quote Martin Luther King while remaining in predominantly white churches, oppose racism in principle while declining to integrate their institutions in practice. CRT is attempting to make this impossible. It says you cannot claim to be colorblind while benefiting from systems that sort by color, you cannot claim to be anti-racist while maintaining segregated institutions, you cannot ignore systemic injustice. What threatens evangelicals is not, finally, the truth of CRT's analysis. It is that CRT will not let us hide anymore.

## WHAT GENUINE REPENTANCE WOULD REQUIRE

**THE DEVASTATING PART IS** that Scripture offers a vision of racial justice more searching than CRT could. The gospel offers reconciliation where CRT can only offer justice; it offers transformation where CRT can only offer structural change. Had white evangelicalism actually offered that vision — had evangelicals said, the gospel demands that we integrate our churches, our schools, our communities, and we are leading the way — the tradition would have the standing to critique CRT. Instead it did the

If white evangelicalism wanted the credibility to critique CRT, the requirements would be concrete and costly. It would need to reckon honestly with the history of the segregation academies, acknowledging what they were and what they were for. It would need to account honestly for why evangelical institutions remain overwhelmingly segregated, with reasons more searching than "it happened that way." It would need to commit to integration of leadership in ways that cost something — not token diversity but substantive change. It would need to teach the actual history of evangelicalism and race to the next generation, not the sanitized version but the whole story. It would need to support Black-led institutions and Black evangelical voices without trying to control them. And it would need to commit to structural change that redistributes resources and power. That is the work of genuine repentance, the work that would give white evangelicalism the moral authority to speak prophetically about the real problems with CRT. Until that work is done, when evangelicals attack CRT they sound like people trying to silence a voice that is naming their own sin — because that is largely what is happening.



## CHAPTER 9

# Black Church Theology

*The prophetic tradition white Christianity ignored –  
Exodus, Cone, Thurman, and the spirituals*

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*The Black church understood  
systemic injustice centuries before  
Critical Race Theory gave it academic  
language.*

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## WHAT WHITE CHRISTIANITY MISSED AND STILL REFUSES TO LEARN

**THERE IS A THEOLOGICAL** tradition in America deeper, more searching, and more prophetic than white evangelical theology has any claim to be – the theology of the Black church, a theology forged in suffering, a

## THE EXODUS THEOLOGY OF THE BLACK CHURCH

**THE BLACK CHURCH UNDERSTOOD** Exodus as the central biblical narrative — not merely the story of Israel escaping Egypt, but the story of God liberating enslaved people. When Black Christians read Exodus, they read their own story. "Let my people go" was the word, and it was God's word to the slaveholder: let them go, you do not own them, they are God's people, they must be free.

White Christianity had effectively abandoned that theology. It had read the Bible in terms of individual salvation — Jesus died for your sins, repent and believe — which is true theology, but incomplete; the white church had minimized the liberationist element of Scripture. The Black church never abandoned it. The Black church understood that faith without liberation is not faith, that God cares about systems of oppression, that the God of Exodus is the God who breaks chains. This is not radicalism. It is biblical. But white Christianity had so thoroughly domesticated the gospel that liberation felt subversive when Black Christians named it.

## JAMES CONE AND THE THEOLOGY OF LIBERATION

first major Black systematic theologian in America, writing in the 1960s and 1970s amid the civil rights movement and the Black Power movement, and he asked a question white Christianity was not asking: what does the gospel say to Black people who are being oppressed? His answer was subversive — God is on the side of the oppressed, God's liberation is the central theme of Scripture, and the Cross is not only about individual forgiveness but about liberation, Jesus's victory over death a victory for the oppressed over systems of death.

Cone said that if the gospel is not good news to the oppressed, it is not the gospel; if Jesus did not come to liberate the enslaved, then Jesus is not the Jesus of Scripture; if the church does not side with the oppressed against the oppressor, then the church is not the church of Jesus. This was too demanding for white Christianity, which wanted a gospel that worked for the middle class, affirmed American values, and did not challenge the systems that benefited white people. Cone offered something different — a gospel that made sense of suffering, that explained why God would allow oppression not to teach the oppressed a lesson, but to call the oppressed to liberation and to call the oppressor to repentance. This is not the gospel white Christianity was teaching.

## **HOWARD THURMAN AND THE SPIRITUAL DISCIPLINE OF SUFFERING**

**HOWARD THURMAN, A GENERATION** before Cone, was a pastor and theologian who worked with both white and Black audiences, and he wrote about Jesus and the



This is not to romanticize suffering. Suffering is not good; oppression is not good. But suffering can deepen a person's capacity for faith, for hope, for love — the oppressed, having nothing else to depend on, depend on God, and having no other comfort, find comfort in prayer and in community. White Christianity, uncomfortable with this truth, largely ignored Thurman, yet his theology is deep, and his charge is plain: listen to people who suffer, for they have something to teach you about faith. This is what the Black church has always done — gathering people who had suffered, and in that gathering creating a space where suffering could be named, where community could be experienced, where God could be met.

### **THE SPIRITUALS: THEOLOGY FORGED IN SUFFERING**

**ONE OF THE DEEPEST** sources of Black church theology is the spirituals — the songs enslaved people created. These are not entertainment. They are theology set to music. "I Want to Go Home" speaks of heaven, but the home is freedom; heaven is not merely spiritual escape but the freedom the enslaved could not find on earth. "Go

"Wade in the Water" tells enslaved people how to escape — follow the North Star, wade in the water so the dogs cannot track you. It is survival theology, practical wisdom, faith that trusts God while taking action. "Swing Low, Sweet Chariot" speaks of a chariot that will carry the singers home, of death, but also of hope — that death is not the end, that there is something beyond this suffering, that God has not abandoned the people. These songs are theology, deeper than most theological treatises because they come from the place where faith has to be real; they come from people who could have given up on God, who could have concluded that God did not care about their suffering, but who instead sang, believed, and testified that God sees them, God loves them, God will act. White Christianity has largely treated these spirituals as entertainment. We have sung them in concert, taught them in school as cultural artifacts, but we have not learned from them — we have not let them teach us about the God who sides with the oppressed.

## **THE PROPHETIC PREACHING TRADITION WHITE CHURCHES LOST**

**THE PREACHING IN THE** Black church differs from the preaching in the white church. White evangelical preaching tends to be expository or topical — it explains the text or explains a doctrine, and it is cerebral. Black church preaching is prophetic: it reads the Scripture in the context of the congregation's reality, names what is happening in the world — injustice, suffering, oppression

This tradition is biblical. It is what the prophets did. It is what Jesus did when he stood up in the synagogue and read Isaiah.

*The Spirit of the Lord is on me, because he has anointed me to proclaim good news to the poor... to proclaim freedom for the prisoners... to set the oppressed free.*

LUKE 4:18

**THEN JESUS SAID, "TODAY** this scripture is fulfilled in your hearing" (Luke 4:21). He was reading the Scripture into the context of his people's reality; he was saying, God is speaking to your situation right now. The Black church has maintained this tradition, reading Scripture as a living word that speaks to the congregation's actual life, preaching as if it matters, as if God cares about what the people are facing, as if the gospel is not a spiritual abstraction but a concrete word for a concrete people. White churches have largely abandoned this. White evangelical churches preach as if the gospel is timeless and contextless, as if the congregation has no particular reality the gospel needs to address, as if the gospel concerns the spiritual realm and has little to do with justice, systems, economics, politics. This is not biblical preaching. It is domesticated preaching.

## **WHAT WHITE CHRISTIANITY LOST IN THE REFUSAL**

to listen to Black church theology, it lost a living connection to the liberating God of Exodus; an understanding of how faith actually works in contexts of suffering; a prophetic tradition that reads Scripture as a living word for the congregation's reality; an appreciation for how the oppressed develop spiritual depths the comfortable do not reach; and a vision of God that is not domesticated, not patriotic, not comfortable, but revolutionary. What it gained in exchange was comfort, respectability, access to power, and the ability to domesticate the gospel to serve the status quo. That was a bad trade. That was a betrayal of the gospel.

## THE ONGOING REFUSAL

**EVEN NOW, EVEN AS** white Christianity is beginning to acknowledge that it got race wrong, it remains largely ignorant of Black church theology. White seminary students do not study Cone as part of their core curriculum; white evangelical churches do not invite Black pastors to teach about the theology of liberation; white denominational leaders do not consult Black theologians as authorities on what the gospel means. The refusal continues — the white church goes on treating Black church theology as a supplement, as something to learn "about" Black people rather than as a central source of Christian wisdom.

This is racism. Not overt racism. Institutional racism — the refusal to recognize that Black church theologians are authorities on what Christianity should be, the refusal to treat the Black church as an equal dialogue partner. As long as this

## THE PROPHETIC WORD

**THE BLACK CHURCH HAS** a prophetic word for white Christianity, and that word is this: you have domesticated the gospel, turned it into a religion that serves your comfort, made it possible to be Christian while maintaining oppression, created theology that justifies injustice. This is not a new word — the prophets have been saying it to the people of God for thousands of years — but the Black church is saying it specifically and prophetically to white Christianity. The question is whether white Christianity will listen, or whether we will continue to refuse the gift the Black church is offering. The answer will determine whether Christianity in America can be prophetic, or whether it will remain domesticated.

## CHAPTER 10

# Racial Reconciliation Is Not Enough

*Why the Bible demands justice before unity, and what  
cheap reconciliation costs*

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**A PARTICULAR PROBLEM HAS** shadowed the American church's approach to racial reconciliation, and it is not a problem of insufficient goodwill. It is a problem of order. We have tried to reconcile without first doing justice, and the attempt has produced something that wears reconciliation's face without its substance. The church has said: let us simply love each other, simply be brothers and sisters in Christ, simply lean on our common faith and move past the division of race.

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*Reconciliation built on injustice is  
not reconciliation. It is complicity.*

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and it is not biblical. The Scriptures are clear that justice must precede peace; a reconciliation built on unaddressed injustice is not reconciliation at all. It is complicity wearing the language of grace.

## WHAT CHEAP RECONCILIATION LOOKS LIKE

**CHEAP RECONCILIATION IS WHAT** happens when the person who has been harmed is asked to forgive before the person who did the harm confesses and makes restitution. Consider a marriage: if one spouse has been unfaithful, cheap reconciliation sounds like, "I did wrong, but I don't want to talk about it; let's just move forward, let's just focus on loving each other now." The unfaithful spouse refuses the work of confession and restitution, while the faithful spouse is asked to forgive without ever receiving an apology. This does not work in a marriage. It does not work in a nation, and it does not work in a church.

Cheap reconciliation in race sounds much the same: let us not focus on what happened in the past, let us just be united now, let us be colorblind, let us not bring up old divisions. Underneath the gentle phrasing, this asks Black Christians to set aside the injustice they have experienced — to forgive without the white church confessing and changing, to pretend that centuries of slavery, segregation, and marginalization do not weigh on the present. This is not reconciliation. This is silencing. It becomes a way for those in power to preserve the status quo while claiming to want unity.

**THE PROPHETS REFUSE THE** shortcut. Their witness is consistent: justice must come before peace, and the order cannot be reversed without falsifying both. Isaiah names the sequence directly.

*Justice will dwell in the desert and righteousness will live in the fertile field. The fruit of that righteousness will be peace; its effect will be quietness and confidence forever.*

ISAIAH 32:16-17

**NOTICE THE ORDER HE** gives. Justice first, then righteousness, then peace, and only then the quietness and confidence that follow. Reverse it, and what you produce is not peace but a false peace — oppression with a friendly face. Amos presses the same vision into a single image.

*Let justice roll on like a river, righteousness like a never-failing stream!*

AMOS 5:24

**AMOS DESCRIBES A MOVEMENT** in which justice is the primary thing, rolling on like a river — not a peaceful coexistence negotiated around the wound, but justice itself as the current. Micah reduces the requirement to its essentials.

*What does the Lord require of you? To act justly and to love mercy and to walk humbly with your God.*

MICAH 6:8

**EVEN HERE, JUSTICE STANDS** first and mercy follows;



## RECONCILIATION WITHOUT REPENTANCE IS CHEAP GRACE

**DIETRICH BONHOEFFER DREW THE** line between cheap grace and costly grace. Cheap grace is grace without discipleship, grace without repentance, grace without cost — the grace that says you are forgiven and may remain exactly as you were. Reconciliation without repentance is cheap grace applied to race, and naming it that way clarifies what is actually missing.

True reconciliation, by contrast, has a shape. The person who did the harm confesses it. The person who did the harm takes steps to change the structures that produced it. The person who did the harm makes restitution where restitution is possible. The person who was harmed receives a genuine apology and compensation. And both parties commit to the new relationship that follows. Only when these steps are taken does reconciliation become real.

The American church has wanted to skip the first four and arrive at the fifth — reconciliation without the labor of justice. When the white church says to the Black church, "Let's just be reconciled," without confessing what was done, without altering its structures, without making restitution, the Black church rightly hears something else underneath: a request to fall silent about injustice and pretend all is well so that the powerful can feel better about themselves. That is cheap grace. It is not the gospel.

**JUSTICE IN THE WAKE** of racial harm asks for several concrete things, and the first is honest historical reckoning. The white church must tell the full story of what it did — not the sanitized version but the whole of it: the segregation academies, the defense of slavery, the silence during the civil rights years, the ongoing segregation of institutions and leadership. Many white churches will not do this; many have rewritten their own history to minimize their complicity, telling stories of how progressive and ahead of their time they were. The record does not support those stories. Honest reckoning means telling the truth even when the truth is uncomfortable.

The second requirement is institutional change. Changing hearts is not enough if the structures stay intact, because a church can feel sincere regret over its racial history while keeping all-white leadership, all-white staff, and all-white pews. Justice asks for actual structural change — hiring Black leaders, investing in Black communities, dismantling the systems that keep congregations segregated.

The third is resource redistribution. The wealth of the white church was built, in part, by benefiting from systems of injustice, and justice therefore asks that resources be redistributed: funding Black churches, supporting Black businesses, working to close the wealth gap. This will cost something, because real justice costs. If your reconciliation costs you nothing, it is not reconciliation. It is performance.

The fourth is changed power dynamics. As long as white people remain in power and Black people remain at the margins, there is no reconciliation; real reconciliation

## THE DANGER OF PREMATURE RECONCILIATION

### **PREMATURE RECONCILIATION IS DANGEROUS**

precisely because it forecloses the deep healing it claims to offer. Reconcile before doing justice, and you reconcile around the injustice rather than through it; the wound stays embedded in the relationship. Later the injustice resurfaces — the one who was harmed feels the harm again, and the one who was never held accountable feels entitled to keep his power. Reconciliation that comes too early is reconciliation that will not hold.

## THE SOUTH AFRICA MODEL AND THE GOSPEL'S VISION

**SOUTH AFRICA OFFERS** A crucial example of what real reconciliation demands. After apartheid, the country could have chosen simple retribution — killing the perpetrators — or premature reconciliation, simply moving on without addressing the past. It chose neither. Through the Truth and Reconciliation Commission, perpetrators of apartheid violence admitted what they had done, victims heard those admissions, and communities began the work of healing; some perpetrators were held accountable, and some were granted amnesty on the condition of full confession. The process was not perfect, but it attempted to hold justice

And yet the gospel does offer genuine reconciliation — reconciliation built on the foundation of justice, not in place of it. Jesus teaches that if you bring your offering to the altar and remember that your brother has something against you, you are to leave the offering and go be reconciled first.

*Therefore, if you are offering your gift at the altar and there remember that your brother or sister has something against you, leave your gift there in front of the altar. First go and be reconciled to them; then come and offer your gift.*

MATTHEW 5:23-24

**THE ORDER MATTERS: RECONCILIATION** comes before the offering. But notice who is told to move. You are the one who has done wrong, and you must go, you must initiate, you must make it right. Paul writes to Philemon about Onesimus in the same key. He does not ask Philemon merely to forgive and move on; he asks him to receive Onesimus "no longer as a slave, but better than a slave, as a beloved brother." Paul is asking for a fundamental change in the relationship — no more slave-master dynamic, now brother and brother. That is reconciliation built on justice: the injustice of slavery is ended, the relationship is remade, and only then does

## THE WORK THE AMERICAN CHURCH MUST DO

**IF THE AMERICAN CHURCH** wants genuine racial reconciliation, the work in front of it is plain. It must tell the full truth about its racial history. It must change its structures so that Black people hold real power and voice. It must redistribute resources to close racial wealth gaps. It must support Black-led churches and institutions without trying to control them. It must make reparative justice a priority rather than an afterthought. And it must accept that reconciliation will take generations, not years.

This is the costly work, and it is the only work that actually produces reconciliation. Without it there will be no reconciliation — only racial management, only the appearance of progress while the injustice quietly persists. The gospel demands justice; it demands that the one who has wronged others do the work of restitution and change, and that reconciliation be built on that foundation. Until the American church does this work, the American church is not reconciled. It is still divided. And the division is still rooted in injustice.

## CHAPTER 11

# Raising Children to See Race Biblically

*A path between colorblindness and critical theory for  
Christian parents*

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**YOUR CHILD IS GOING** to notice that people have different skin colors, that some people are treated differently, that certain faces are missing from the rooms where decisions get made. That noticing will not wait for your permission; it will arrive through peers, through school, through media, through the ordinary traffic of a world your child is learning to read. The only question left to you is the one you actually get to answer: what will you, as a Christian parent, teach your child about race?

Most Christian parents have worked from one of two frameworks, and each one feels, from the inside, like the responsible choice. The colorblind framework says we do not notice race, we treat everyone the same, race does not matter. The critical framework says race is the primary lens through which we understand everything, that power dynamics are

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*The only question left to you is the one  
you actually get to answer: what will  
you teach your child about race?*

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## THE PROBLEM WITH COLORBLINDNESS

**COLORBLINDNESS SOUNDS BEAUTIFUL.** IT sounds like the dream Dr. King named on the steps of the Lincoln Memorial—that people would be judged not by the color of their skin but by the content of their character. The aspiration is real, and it is worth honoring. But the framework that grew up around it is not what the Bible teaches. Scripture does not ask us to stop seeing color; it tells us that God saw the color, saw the ethnicity, and called it good.

*From one man he made all the nations, that they should  
inhabit the whole earth; and he marked out their  
appointed times in history and the boundaries of their  
lands.*

ACTS 17:26

**GOD MADE THE NATIONS.** God made the diversity. God looked at what he had made and said it was very good. To teach a child not to see what God created as good is not

Consider the child who asks why all the presidents look like grandpa. If your answer is that we do not notice those things, you have not protected innocence—you have taught a small person to stop seeing, to stop tracking patterns, to stop asking why the world is ordered the way it is. That is not the preservation of innocence; it is the manufacture of blindness, and it quietly disables the very capacity a child needs in order to recognize injustice later. Colorblindness carries a second cost, too, one borne unequally: tell a child of color that you do not notice race, and you have told that child you will not acknowledge an important part of who they are, that their experience of the world—which includes their race—is something you would rather not see. Colorblindness is not a virtue. It is a failure to see.

### **THE PROBLEM WITH UNCRITICAL ADOPTION OF CRT**

**THE OPPOSITE ERROR IS** just as available. Adopt the system of Critical Race Theory wholesale and you teach your child that identity is primarily about power, that the self and everyone else are to be read first through the lens of oppression or being oppressed. This creates its own distortions. It can teach a child of color that their primary identity is victim; it can teach a white child that their primary identity is oppressor; and it can keep both from seeing the full complexity of a human person.

The deeper problem lies underneath those effects. To



## WHAT BIBLICAL PARENTING ABOUT RACE LOOKS LIKE

**BIBLICAL PARENTING ABOUT RACE** starts with one foundational claim: every person bears the image of God. Not the white person. Not the Black person. Every person—male and female, rich and poor, powerful and marginalized—is God's beloved, created in God's image. From that foundation, several things can be taught, and they hold together only because they rest on it.

First, ethnicity is real and beautiful. You can teach your child about different cultures—the food, the music, the traditions, the particular beauty of different peoples—and you can teach that ethnicity is a gift, not a problem. If your child is of color, you can teach them to be proud of their heritage, to know the contributions their people have made and the strength of their traditions. If your child is white, you can teach them about their heritage too: not as superior, not as the default human, but as theirs—one particular way of being human among many.

Second, race creates real consequences in the world, and your child needs to hear you name it in age-appropriate ways. When your child comes home and says the principal is always a white man, the answer is not that we do not notice those

## TEACHING RESPONSIBILITY WITHOUT SHAME

**THIRD, BEING BENEFITED BY** injustice does not make you bad. If your child is white and you are teaching them about racial injustice, you must be careful not to teach them that they are bad because they are white. That is not biblical, and it produces shame where it should produce responsibility. There is a better sentence to give a child: you have benefited from systems that were unfair to other people; that is not your fault; your ancestors did not create those systems, but they benefited from them, and you benefit from them now—you did not choose that, but now that you know, you have a choice about whether you will work to change them. You teach responsibility, not shame.

Fourth, we are all called to work for justice. The God of the Bible is a God of justice who cares about systems that exploit the vulnerable and who calls his people to pursue what is right. You can teach your child that justice is not political but biblical—that it means pursuing systems that are fair to everyone, and using whatever power or privilege you have to help people who have less. You can teach your child to pay attention to what is fair and unfair, to speak up when something is unfair, and to understand that sometimes doing the right thing costs something.

## **PRACTICAL WAYS TO TEACH CHILDREN ABOUT RACE**

**HOW DO YOU ACTUALLY** do this? Mostly in the ordinary furniture of a household. Read diverse stories, so that the books in your home include Black protagonists, Asian protagonists, Latino protagonists—people of color as the main characters, not merely the supporting ones. Celebrate diverse holidays; if you are white, celebrate your own heritage, but also learn and celebrate the heritage of your neighbors and friends, not as exotic curiosities but as legitimate parts of your community's life.

Build diverse friendships, and take seriously what it means if your child has only white friends—not because white friends are bad, but because a child who never crosses that line is not learning to see the full humanity of people different from themselves. So build those friendships on purpose: go to churches that are integrated, schools that are diverse, neighborhoods that are not segregated. And have

Name injustice when you see it. When a child of color is treated unfairly, name it; when a system is working against a particular group, name it; model for your child that noticing and naming injustice is normal and healthy. Teach them their own history, and teach it real rather than sanitized. If your child is of color, teach them the contributions their people have made, the struggles their people have faced, the figures from their tradition who worked for justice—and teach them about slavery and segregation and the people who resisted and fought for freedom. If your child is white, teach them their real history too: where the family came from, the family's relationship to issues of race, the complicity where it is there and the resistance where it is there.

Above all, do justice, do not merely teach it, because your actions teach more than your words. Teach your child to work for justice while you work to maintain segregation, and your child will notice the contradiction. Teach your child that race matters while your church stays all white, and your child will notice. Teach your child that all people are equal while voting for policies that harm people of color, and your child will notice. Live what you teach. That is where the real teaching happens.

## THE RISK AND THE HOPE

**NONE OF THIS IS** safe. Teaching a child to see race clearly and to work for justice carries a real risk: your child might get angry, might grow disillusioned with

The hope runs the other direction. It is the hope of raising a child who sees clearly, who loves fully, who works for justice, who believes reconciliation is possible, and who trusts that God is in control even when the work is hard. That is what biblical parenting about race looks like.

## CHAPTER 12

# Building a Church That Does Justice and Loves Mercy

*Moving a congregation from reaction and diversity to  
justice and shared power*

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**FOR YEARS, THE AMERICAN** church has been reactive on race. The culture shifts, and the church scrambles to respond; someone launches an initiative, and the church either opposes it or adopts it without thinking; critical race theory arrives in the public square, and the church panics. This is not leadership. It is reaction, and underneath the reaction is fear.

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*What if the church led on racial  
justice instead of reacting to it?*

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grounded in Scripture and in the gospel, offered a vision of justice and reconciliation more searching than anything the culture was offering? That is possible. But it requires a fundamental shift in how churches actually operate, and that shift begins by refusing to confuse a feeling with a structure.

## WHAT JUSTICE ACTUALLY LOOKS LIKE IN A LOCAL CHURCH

**JUSTICE IS NOT ABSTRACT**, and it is not a social policy you adopt and then file away; justice is how a church actually operates day to day. It is whom you hire, how you distribute resources, whom you listen to, and whom you make decisions alongside. A church that does justice does five concrete things, and none of them are optional.

First, it has diverse leadership — not diversity for its own sake, but leadership that genuinely reflects the community the church sits inside. If your church is in a diverse neighborhood and your leadership is all white, something is wrong, and naming it is the beginning of honesty. This means actually recruiting, hiring, and ordaining people of color; it means paying them equally; it means trusting them with real power rather than handing out token positions. The work is hard because it requires admitting you have been wrong about who is qualified to lead, it requires white leaders stepping aside to make space, and it requires resources to support the transition. But for justice it is non-negotiable.

Second, it listens to voices it has long ignored. For years, white churches have preached about what Black people need from the church, what they should do, and what they should accept. Justice requires actually asking — not in token

Third, it uses its resources to support justice, because money talks and a budget reveals what a church truly values. A church that funds new facilities but not the cause of racial justice is saying something out loud whether it means to or not. Justice requires redistributing resources — funding Black churches, supporting Black pastors through education and mentorship, investing in Black communities, and paying Black staff equally and generously. This costs something, and that is the point: real justice costs.

Fourth, it changes systems, because changing individual attitudes is not enough. If a church has been segregated for a hundred years, it cannot simply announce that everyone is welcome now; it has to actively dismantle the systems that produce segregation, asking why the church is segregated, what maintains that segregation, and what integration would actually require. Sometimes that means changing where you meet, sometimes the style of worship, sometimes the very theological grid you have been teaching. All of these changes cost. All of them create discomfort. All of them are necessary.

Fifth, it teaches the full history. Sunday school and Bible studies cannot offer only the comfortable past; they must teach the past that is true. What did your denomination do during slavery — defend it or oppose it? During segregation — maintain it or resist it? During the civil rights movement — stay silent, oppose, or support? Teach the full truth, and if the



## THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN DIVERSITY AND JUSTICE

**HERE IS A DISTINCTION** many churches miss: diversity is not the same as justice. Diversity means you have people of different races present in your church, which is good — but diversity can be purely cosmetic. You can have Black members in the congregation while maintaining an all-white leadership; you can have Black people in the pews while treating them as less than.

Justice means that power, resources, and voice are genuinely shared. It means people of color are not merely represented but actually listened to and trusted; it means resources are distributed in ways that address historical inequities. You can have diversity without justice, and many churches do — Black faces in the congregation and in the marketing materials while the structures of injustice stay intact. But you cannot have justice without diversity. If only white people hold positions of power, if only white perspectives shape decisions, if only white people control the resources, then whatever you have, it is not justice.

## THE GOSPEL VISION FOR MULTIETHNIC COMMUNITY

**WHAT WOULD A LOCAL** church look like if it actually lived the gospel's vision of community? It would be a place where people of different backgrounds could gather without anyone being pressed to assimilate into someone else's cultural form, where difference was celebrated as a

It would be a place where the history of injustice was acknowledged, where repentance was real and restitution was attempted; a place where the prophetic tradition was alive, where injustice was named and comfort was not the goal. It would be a place where reconciliation was possible — not easy, but possible — where people once divided by injustice could become family again. This is the vision of the book of Acts, where Jews and Gentiles gathered together, where people from different nations understood one another as family, where resources were shared and the barriers that had divided people were broken down. This is not an outdated vision. It is one the church desperately needs to recover.

## THE PROPHETIC ROLE OF THE CHURCH

**THE CHURCH'S ROLE IN** the culture should be prophetic, which means it speaks truth the culture does not want to hear; it names injustice when the culture is comfortable, and it calls for justice when the powerful do not want to change. For too long the American church has been captured by its culture instead — baptizing American values, wrapping the flag and the cross together, making it possible to be Christian while maintaining injustice.

A prophetic church cannot do this. It must say plainly that the injustice is wrong, the system is broken, this must change. But the prophetic church does not stop at naming the problem; it offers an alternative vision, saying here is what

## STARTING WHERE YOU ARE — AND COUNTING THE COST

**YOU DO NOT HAVE** to be a mega-church or a major denomination to do this work; you can start where you are. If you are a pastor, you can begin by telling the truth about your denomination's racial history, by inviting voices you have not listened to before, and by asking hard questions about your own church's systems. If you are a member, you can ask your leadership why the leadership team is all white, why most of the giving goes to building maintenance rather than racial justice, and why people of color in the congregation are not being heard.

If you are a church planter, you can plant a church with integration as a core value from the very beginning, building structures of shared power from the start and making clear that this is a congregation where people of all races are not just welcome but fully valued. If you are a seminary student, you can demand that your seminary teach the full history of Christianity and race, that the faculty include voices from the Black church tradition, and that racial justice sit at the center of theological education rather than at its margins. The work does not require permission from denominational leadership or the approval of powerful institutions. It requires commitment.

Let me be honest: doing justice in a local church will cost

But here is what justice also offers: integrity — the possibility of actually living what you say you believe, and the possibility that your church might become a glimpse of the kingdom of God, a place where people of all races and backgrounds gather as family.

## THE HOPE

**THE HOPE IS NOT** that the American church will do racial justice perfectly. We will make mistakes, move imperfectly, and struggle. The hope is that the American church could be prophetic — that it could lead on racial justice instead of lagging behind, that it could offer the culture a vision of reconciliation deeper than the culture can offer on its own.

The gospel has power to reconcile, power to transform, power to make enemies into family. A church that actually believes the gospel and actually practices it could be a sign of that power; it could show the world what becomes possible when people take the cross seriously — when they truly believe that Christ has broken down the wall between us. That

**BUILDING A CHURCH THAT DOES JUSTICE AND LOVES  
MERCY**

## CONCLUSION

# The Cross and the Color Line

*Why the gospel demands more of the church than any  
secular theory of justice*

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*The cross is the ultimate statement  
about racial justice.*

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## WHAT THE CROSS SAYS AND WHAT IT BREAKS

**CRITICAL RACE THEORY IS** not the gospel. It cannot save you, it cannot heal you, it cannot reconcile enemies, and it cannot transform the human heart. What it can do is name injustice, identify systems, and call attention to patterns that matter; for that much we can be grateful. But

At the cross, a Roman instrument of execution becomes an instrument of redemption; a condemned criminal is executed in the most shameful way the empire could devise; and all the hierarchies of Rome—power, status, culture—are exposed as illusion. Consider who is crucified. The God-man, Jesus: the one who has all authority, the one who is equal with God, the one deserving of worship and power. He is the one nailed up to die.

Now consider who is saved. Not the powerful—the Gospels record that the powerful mocked Jesus on the cross, that the religious leaders, the people in authority, rejected him. The ones saved are the thieves and the women, the gentiles and the outcast, the people the system had already condemned, the people the law had already thrown away, the people who held no status, no power, no claim on the kingdom. That is the cross: the ultimate reversal, where the most powerful becomes the most powerless, the most righteous becomes the most condemned, the judge becomes the judged. And through that shame, redemption comes; through that death, life comes.

So the cross breaks every hierarchy—the hierarchy of race, the hierarchy of power, the hierarchy of status. Paul makes the claim explicit.

*As many of you as were baptized into Christ have clothed*

GALATIANS 3:27-28

**THE BARRIERS ARE BROKEN—NOT** in theory, not in some distant spiritual realm, but in practice, in the church, in the body of Christ. If the church really is that body, then it should be the first place racial hierarchies fall, the place where the most marginalized person carries as much voice, as much value, as much power as the most privileged. This is not a political statement. It is a theological one. It is what the gospel means.

**WHAT THE AMERICAN CHURCH HAS DONE INSTEAD**

**INSTEAD OF EMBODYING WHAT** the cross breaks, the American church has reinforced it. It has maintained racial hierarchy, kept the most marginalized in the back, and handed power and voice and resources to the privileged. Worse, it has done this theologically—building doctrine that justifies injustice, that tells the oppressed to be patient, that assures the privileged their privilege is no responsibility of theirs. This is not the gospel. This is a denial of it.

**THE GOSPEL'S RADICAL DEMAND BEYOND JUSTICE**

**HERE IS WHAT MAKES** the gospel more demanding than any secular theory: it does not just require that systems change—it requires that we change. CRT can call for systemic change and demand that structures be



*Love your enemies, bless those who curse you, do good to those who hate you, and pray for those who spitefully use you and persecute you.*

MATTHEW 5:44

**THIS IS NOT POLITICAL** wisdom and it is not strategy; it is subversion. It is the demand that you would actually prefer the good of the person you have hurt over your own comfort, that you would work for their liberation—not because it benefits you, but because they are God's beloved.

*Greater love has no one than this: to lay down one's life for one's friends.*

JOHN 15:13

**AND JESUS SAYS THIS** to the very people he is about to die for, the people about to betray him, the people who will benefit from his death—the faithful, yes, but not only the faithful. The betrayer too. The denier too. The mockers too. The gospel demands everything: that you become a new creation, that your self-interest dies, that you are willing to sacrifice your own advantage for the sake of the other. That is what reconciliation requires—not just justice, but justice plus a willingness to die for the enemy.

And this is exactly what the American church has become too comfortable to offer. It has grown too invested in keeping

### THE VISION THAT IS POSSIBLE

**AND YET THE GOSPEL'S** vision is possible—not easy, not quick, but possible. There are churches already doing this work: congregations where people of different races gather as family, leadership teams where power is genuinely shared, communities where resources are actually distributed, places where the cross is breaking down the walls. These are not the mega-churches or the famous ones. But they exist, and they point to what could be: a church that actually believes the gospel, that practices reconciliation instead of merely preaching it, where the cross has its real power—breaking every hierarchy and making new what was divided.

So the prophetic task for the American church right now is not to defend itself against CRT; it is to offer something better. To offer a vision of justice rooted in God's character rather than human theory, a vision of reconciliation rooted in the blood of Christ rather than human ability to forgive. To say to the culture: you are right that something is wrong, you are right that systems are broken, you are right that injustice is embedded in our institutions—but we offer you more than a

What that requires is a fundamental shift in how white Christianity understands itself. It must admit: we have gotten this wrong. We defended slavery, we maintained segregation, we built theology to justify injustice, we stayed comfortable while the marginalized suffered, we refused to repent in ways that cost. That admission is hard; it requires humility; it requires being willing to be wrong. But until white Christianity makes it, white Christianity cannot move forward, and it cannot offer the gospel's vision of reconciliation.

The hope this book offers, then, is not easy hope. It is not the hope that says everything will be fine now that we are paying attention to race, nor that systemic change will be quick, nor that reconciliation will be comfortable. It is costly hope—the hope that says the work of justice is hard and will take generations, that reconciliation requires sacrifice and will cost us something, that we will make mistakes and will have to keep repenting. But it is also real hope, because the gospel is real, because the cross is real, because Christ has already paid the ultimate price. The gospel does not promise that justice will be easy; it promises that justice is possible, that enemies can become family, that what is divided can be reconciled. Not cheap hope. Costly hope. The only hope worth believing in.

**THE CALL: WILL THE CHURCH ACTUALLY  
BELIEVE THE GOSPEL?**

the American church comes down to a single question: will you actually believe the gospel? Will you actually dismantle systems of injustice, or maintain them? Will you actually listen to voices you have ignored, or keep speaking for others? Will you actually share power, or perform diversity while keeping control? Will you actually repent—changing your mind and your behavior—or pretend you did not know what you did? Will you actually lay down your life for the other—for the person of color you have harmed, for the people you have excluded, for the communities you have marginalized—or will you ask them to accept your comfort as reconciliation? Will you actually become the body of Christ, or remain a white institution with a cross on top?

The gospel's demand is clear. Its vision is clear. Its power is real. The question is what the American church will do with it—and that question will determine whether Christianity in America is prophetic or complicit, whether the church is a sign of the gospel or a contradiction of it, whether we point the world toward the cross or away from it. The answer is not yet written. The work is still to be done. The time is now. Will you do it?

## EXPANSIONS 1

# Introduction, Chapters 1-3

*Deeper background – SBC Resolution 9, the scholars,  
the Scriptures, and the buried history*

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*The resolution had meant to settle  
something; instead it clarified what  
had always been true.*

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## SBC RESOLUTION 9 AND THE DEPARTURE OF BLACK PASTORS

**IN JUNE 2019 THE** Southern Baptist Convention did something most people never actually read. The denomination adopted Resolution 9, a statement on

It was an attempt at an impossible thing—to name systemic injustice while keeping institutional distance from the system doing the naming. The resolution tried to have it both ways. Within three years it had fractured the denomination.

What happened in those three years was not that anyone read CRT. What happened is that the term became a sign for something else: for the possibility that white supremacy was embedded in American institutions, for the chance that white Christianity might have to change, for the force that people who felt their power threatened reached for to name the thing threatening them. By 2021 the backlash was visceral. Pastors were writing resolutions against CRT; megachurch pulpits were preaching against it; conservative activists were mobilizing. At its 2021 annual meeting the SBC moved to distance itself from the 2019 resolution, claiming it had been misinterpreted or pushed too far.

Underneath the institutional posturing, something else was happening. Black pastors were leaving. They had never

This was the real crisis—not whether CRT existed, but that the denomination's attempt to manage the conversation had failed to address what Black pastors had actually requested. The SBC wanted the intellectual debate about CRT while avoiding the structural change that justice would require. By 2023 the exodus had grown alarming to denominational leaders. Preachers who had served for decades were walking away; young Black pastors were declining to affiliate at all. The denomination that had built its strength on Black churches—and on the resources those churches generated—was losing the very people who had sustained it.

The resolution had meant to settle something. Instead it clarified what had always been true: the denomination wanted racial justice as long as that justice cost it no power, no resources, no theology—as long as justice could stay an intellectual exercise instead of becoming a structural transformation. The tragedy is not that CRT exists. The tragedy is that a denomination had to be pressed by secular theory even to ask whether its own systems perpetuated injustice, and that when Black pastors asked for change, it took an academic structure gaining cultural traction to make

## **INTERSECTIONALITY, COUNTER-NARRATIVES, AND INTEREST CONVERGENCE**

### **WHEN KIMBERLÉ CRENSHAW PUBLISHED**

"Demarginalizing the Intersection of Race and Sex" in 1989, she was trying to solve a specific legal problem: Black women were falling through the cracks of civil rights law. They could sue for discrimination, but the law required them to prove either race discrimination or sex discrimination; it had no category for a claim that was both at once and reducible to neither. A Black woman fired from a job did not experience racism the way a Black man did, nor sexism the way a white woman did—she experienced a distinct, intersecting harm produced by race and gender operating together. Crenshaw's move was to name that intersection. She was not inventing something new; she was naming something that had always existed. Naming it changed everything.

Intersectionality does not claim that every dimension of identity always matters equally. It claims that identity is never one-dimensional, that systems of power operate along multiple axes at once, and that a person's lived experience is shaped by where they sit in relation to all of those axes simultaneously. The practical implication follows: if you want to understand how injustice operates, you cannot study race



This is where intersectionality becomes threatening to anyone invested in simpler narratives. It refuses to let people off the hook by claiming that only one form of injustice matters or that they are untouched by any axis of oppression. A white woman can oppose racism while benefiting from gender solidarity with white men who also benefit from racial hierarchy; a Black man can be oppressed by racism while holding patriarchal power over Black women. Systems do not sort neatly—people benefit from some hierarchies while being marginalized by others. Crenshaw's structure is not subversive because it is untruthful. It is subversive because it refuses to allow anyone the claim of innocence, and because of the precision with which it names harm.

The second concept CRT scholars developed was the counter-narrative. Richard Delgado and Jean Stefancic observed that legal systems and historical accounts have always been told from the perspective of those in power: American legal history was written by the judges, lawyers, and white men with access to courts and documents, and their narratives became "the" narrative. Counter-narratives are the stories told by people excluded from that official account. They are testimony. A counter-narrative to slavery is not merely an academic reinterpretation; it is the lived testimony of enslaved people—the accounts they created, the songs they sang, the resistance they organized. The claim is that these are not supplements to history or anecdotes that

Here CRT becomes explicitly epistemological—a claim about what counts as knowledge and who gets to be a knower. American law had built a system in which the knowledge of the powerful counted and the testimony of the powerless did not, and CRT scholars insisted this was not objective but a choice, and that different choices would yield different understanding.

Derrick Bell's concept of interest convergence is perhaps the most cynical observation CRT made, and also the most historically accurate. Bell looked at moments of racial progress in America and asked what made the people in power willing to accept them. *Brown v. Board of Education* is the classic case. In 1954 the Supreme Court ruled that "separate but equal" was unconstitutional, that school segregation was inherently unequal, that it had to end. It was a moral and legal victory. But Bell asked: why 1954? Why not 1944, or 1934? His answer was interest convergence. America in 1954 was waging the Cold War, and the Soviet Union held a propaganda advantage—America preached democracy while enforcing segregation, and its image in the world suffered for it. For America's international interests to be served, segregation had to end.

This does not mean those who fought for desegregation lacked genuine conviction. It means progress arrived at the moment justice served the interests of the powerful—and that once Cold War pressure eased, once the world stopped watching, once integration became inconvenient, the

## HOW CRT DIFFERS FROM MARXISM: RACE VS. CLASS

**THEN COMES THE FAMILIAR** allegation: is CRT Marxist? The syllogism runs that CRT came out of the critical legal studies movement, that critical legal studies was influenced by Marxist thought, and therefore CRT is Marxist. This is neither entirely false nor entirely true. Marxist theory is concerned with class; it reads history as driven by class conflict between those who own production and those who labor, and it holds that capitalism inevitably produces oppression and that only revolutionary transformation of the economic system can create justice.

CRT scholars were reading some of the same critical theory, but they were asking a different question. Marxists asked how class determines what is possible; CRT scholars asked how race determines what is possible. And they observed something Marxism could not absorb: you cannot reduce race to class. You cannot say racism is merely a mask for class exploitation, that eliminating class would eliminate racism. The historical evidence refused the claim. In the

This distinction carried weight historically, because Marxist movements in the United States had often asked Black people to set aside racial grievances for the sake of class solidarity—the logic being that all workers are one, that racial division distracts from class consciousness, that race will resolve itself once class is addressed. Black people repeatedly rejected this. Black communists understood class, but they knew poor white workers would still choose whiteness over working-class solidarity, and that the communist movement would still subordinate Black interests to white ones. CRT scholars made a parallel but distinct claim: race is a primary organizing principle in America, not secondary to class, and injustice cannot be addressed by ignoring race or reducing it to something else.

Here CRT's intellectual contribution comes clear, and so do its limits. CRT is precise and historically grounded about how race works in American systems. It has far less to say about what comes after you name those systems. Not a balanced ledger. A diagnosis. CRT is better at diagnosis than prescription—and that gap is exactly where a Christian account has work to do.

That gap matters, because one danger of CRT's rise is co-optation: a movement of critique can be absorbed into the system it set out to critique. It happened before with liberation theology, which emerged to challenge capitalism

What sustains justice work is conviction—the belief that it matters beyond politics, beyond culture, beyond trends. The Black church sustained the civil rights movement because it was rooted in faith, not in political fashion, in the conviction that God cares about justice. A church rooted in the cross, in the belief that Christ died for the marginalized, can carry the work even when the culture turns against it. This is why Christian anthropology matters. It is not enough to name systems; you have to believe that people can change, that the gospel has power to transform hearts and systems, that reconciliation is possible. CRT cannot offer this. The gospel can—and that is precisely the thing the church could offer that no secular theory can, the thing that would give the church credibility to speak prophetically rather than merely compete with CRT.

### **THE TABLE OF NATIONS, BABEL, RUTH, AND RAHAB**

**THE TABLE OF NATIONS** is one of the most deliberately boring passages in Scripture, and its boredom is the point. Genesis 10 lists the descendants of Noah's three sons—from Japheth the peoples of the coastlands, from

The very next chapter explores what happens when that diversity is disrupted. Babel is usually read as punishment: God confuses the languages, scatters the people, prevents the tower from reaching heaven—God punishing human pride by destroying human unity. But there is another reading. The people of Babel wanted one language, one civilization; they wanted to eliminate the very diversity Genesis 10 had established as God's creation; they wanted to consolidate power over land, over one another, against God. God's response was not to punish diversity but to preserve it—to restore the different languages, the different peoples, the inability to fully consolidate power into one totalitarian structure. Not the punishment of diversity. The preservation of it against human attempts to homogenize it for power. In this reading God is defending the Table of Nations, and the whole biblical narrative about ethnicity reframes around a single claim: God loves diversity, God ordained it, and when humans try to destroy it to consolidate power, God resists.

This is the context for understanding Ruth. Ruth is a Moabite, a foreigner from an enemy nation Israel had clashed with repeatedly; she has no claim on the people of Israel, no right to be included in their community. And yet the entire book is about her inclusion. Her name ends up in the genealogy of David. She is not merely included—she is honored, her loyalty to Naomi, her hard work, her moral

Rahab's inclusion is even more demanding. Rahab is a Canaanite, and Canaanites are not merely foreigners but the people God has ordered Israel to drive out—the enemy, under the curse Genesis establishes. And yet Rahab is not driven out. She becomes part of Israel, part of David's genealogy, a hero in the story. How? By crossing a boundary, by siding with the people God is bringing in rather than the people God is displacing, by choosing faithfulness to God over loyalty to her own nation. The pattern holds: people from outside are brought in, people from enemy nations are included, the boundaries that seemed permanent are crossed.

The Samaritan woman at the well is the New Testament version of this. Samaritans were the people Jews looked down on; the woman is a Samaritan, and a woman, and a woman with a complicated sexual history—layers of outsider in the Jewish world. And Jesus speaks to her. He asks her for water; he treats her with dignity; he tells her of the living water; he reveals himself as the Messiah to her before he reveals it to his own disciples. The message is consistent across Scripture: the outsider, the foreigner, the enemy, the one from the other nation—these are exactly the people God is interested in, the ones Jesus seeks out, the ones who become central to the story. This is not abstract theology. It is a statement about whose voice matters, whose testimony counts, whose dignity is non-negotiable.

When the American church excluded people from other nations, excluded people who looked different, built

**BURIED HISTORY: THREE-FIFTHS, DRED SCOTT, RECONSTRUCTION, THE RED SUMMER**

**THE CONSTITUTION OF THE** United States was written by men who owned enslaved people, and they had a problem to solve: how to count enslaved people for purposes of representation without granting them the right to vote. The solution was the three-fifths compromise. Enslaved people would be counted as three-fifths of a person for apportionment—determining how



Where were the churches—the churches that now claim to be the moral conscience of America? When this compromise was written and debated, the churches were silent. The ones that should have said "this is an abomination" said nothing; the ones that should have mobilized prophetic witness against slavery said nothing; the ones that owned enslaved people themselves, and many did, said nothing. The silence had a cost. It meant one of America's founding documents was written with religious sanction, that Christian communities could point to the Constitution and call slavery legitimate, lawful, accepted by society.

One hundred years later Chief Justice Roger Taney wrote the Dred Scott decision. Dred Scott was an enslaved man who sued for his freedom on the grounds that he had been taken to a free state, and Taney's response was brutal: Black people, enslaved or free, had no rights that the white man was bound to respect. He went further, declaring that slavery itself was not wrong and that the Constitution protected it. The Christian response? Churches in the South hailed the decision; Southern theology doubled down; Southern churches grew more aggressive in defending slavery on theological grounds. The decision gave religious language legal authority, and legal authority gave religious language

After the Civil War, Reconstruction offered a moment. For roughly twelve years it looked as if America might actually integrate: Black people were voting, Black men were holding office, Black churches were being built, Black communities were organizing. It was not perfect and not without violence, but the arc of history was bending toward justice. Then white resistance mobilized, and the church was part of it. Southern churches had lost property and influence during the war and Reconstruction; they became organizations of resistance, organizing against Black political participation, and Southern theology justified violence against Black communities. By 1877 Reconstruction was over. The federal government withdrew. White Southern power reasserted itself. Jim Crow was coming, segregation was coming, and the churches that had resisted Reconstruction would be the churches that defended segregation.

The Red Summer of 1919 is barely known by most Americans, white or Black, and it should be remembered the way we remember lynch mobs—because it was organized racial violence, the burning of Black neighborhoods, the murder of Black people, and it happened in the summer Americans were supposed to be celebrating victory in the First World War. In Chicago a young Black man drowned after white swimmers threw rocks at him, a white mob rioted, and the riot burned: thirty-eight people died and over a thousand Black homes were destroyed. The mobs were white. The police protected the mobs. The newspapers covered it as a race riot, as though the violence had been mutual. The

This is the history white Christianity does not teach its children, the history Sunday school omits, the history seminary students never learn unless they go looking for it. Because it is not taught, white Christianity can claim ignorance—we did not know, we were not part of that, that was a different generation. But you cannot claim the benefits of history while refusing to acknowledge its costs. You cannot benefit from the property, the power, the social position built through slavery and segregation and then claim no responsibility for what built it. The churches of America built their wealth on slavery, defended segregation, stayed silent during violence against Black communities, then moved to all-white suburbs and planted new churches in neighborhoods that had been redlined and kept poor. That is the unfinished history. That is what the American church has not confessed.

And it raises the deeper question the whole book is built on—why CRT arrived now, and what it means that a secular structure is naming what Scripture has named all along. For centuries Black Americans spoke about systemic racism; for centuries Black churches taught liberation theology; for centuries Black voices said the systems are rigged, the law is not neutral, racism is embedded in how institutions work. White America did not listen. White Christianity answered that there was no race problem, only individual sinners; that anyone could succeed by working hard; that racism was

This should be shameful for white Christianity: that we needed CRT to tell us what Scripture had been saying all along, that we were more willing to listen to secular academics than to Black prophets. The cost of continued silence is becoming clear—young Black people leaving the church, the church's credibility destroyed, people rightly wondering whether the church can be trusted on racial justice. But the deeper cost is spiritual. To maintain the systems, to choose comfort, to read Scripture in ways that protect the status quo, is not a neutral choice; it is choosing the culture over the gospel. Scripture itself treats injustice not as the mere sum of individual sins but as systemic—something nations participate in, institutions perpetuate, generations inherit.

When Amos spoke to Israel he was not chiefly addressing individual moral failures but a nation that had built its wealth on the oppression of the vulnerable.

*You trample on the heads of the poor as on the dust of the ground and deny justice to the oppressed.*

AMOS 2:7

**THAT IS CORPORATE INDICTMENT.** When Isaiah stood before Jerusalem he was not asking whether any particular person had committed robbery; he was asking whether the city was a city of justice, whether it protected

If the church addresses only personal sin, it preaches half the gospel; if it addresses systemic injustice without the power of the gospel, it preaches a gospel without power. The real gospel addresses both: your personal sins matter and are forgiven in Christ, and your participation in unjust systems matters and can be transformed through the gospel. The American church has largely abandoned half of that, preaching personal salvation while staying silent on systemic injustice, building institutions that perpetuate injustice while claiming the gospel. A church that preached the whole gospel would look radically different—it would unsettle comfortable Christianity, demand structural change, require sacrifice, announce judgment and offer reconciliation, and look like the early church, a countercultural movement that challenged every power structure it met.

Unjust systems do not persist because people are obviously evil. They persist because they are normal—the

How do such systems actually change? When they become unsustainable—when the cost of maintaining them exceeds the benefit, when enough people decide the cost is not worth paying. And when those in power face people who refuse to accept the system, who organize, who refuse to cooperate with their own oppression, who build alternatives proving another way is possible. In the American South, segregation persisted as long as Black people seemed to accept it and cracked when they refused—when they organized and were willing to pay the cost. White people did not desegregate because they suddenly became moral; they desegregated because Black people made segregation too costly. The bus boycott cost the city money. The sit-ins disrupted commerce. The march on Washington demanded change.

Dismantling an unjust system takes pressure from the



## EXPANSIONS 2

# Chapters 4-6

*The church-led civil rights movement, corporate sin,  
and the policies that built the wealth gap*

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*The march on the Edmund Pettus  
Bridge was not a political  
confrontation. It was a liturgical act.*

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## THE MONTGOMERY BOYCOTT AND SELMA AS CHURCH-LED ACTS OF FAITH

**PEOPLE REMEMBER THE MONTGOMERY** bus boycott as a moment of spontaneous courage: a tired woman named Rosa Parks who would not give up her seat, a single refusal that sparked a movement. That is the mythology, and it flattens what actually happened.



White Christianity has largely forgotten this. When we talk about the civil rights movement, we describe a secular social cause that King happened to join; we do not say that the movement was rooted in Black churches, organized by Black pastors, and sustained by church people gathering night after night to pray and sing and strategize.

Selma tells the same story. In 1965, with Black citizens being blocked from registering to vote, the churches organized a fifty-four-mile march from Selma to Montgomery to demand voting rights. They did not march as a political party. They marched as a religious movement—singing hymns, praying, carrying the spiritual tradition of the Black church into the streets.

When state troopers on horseback beat marchers with whips on the Edmund Pettus Bridge, that was not a political confrontation; it was a liturgical act. People were sacrificing their bodies, submitting to violence without retaliating, bearing witness. This is what the Black church tradition understood about resistance: that resistance is an act of faith,

## KING'S CRITIQUE OF CAPITALISM AND MILITARISM

**MOST WHITE EVANGELICAL CHURCHES** have domesticated King into a safe figure—the dreamer who wanted integration, who was nonviolent, who asked nicely for equality. The real King was asking for something far more demanding. In *Where Do We Go from Here: Chaos or Community?* he explicitly attacked capitalism, arguing that "the profit motive alone is not adequate to meet the needs of every member of the society." This is the King white Christianity does not teach, the King who threatens the status quo.

He was not requesting minor reforms to help poor people; he was calling for a fundamental restructuring of the economy, arguing that capitalism itself—not merely racist capitalism, but capitalism as such—produced poverty and exploitation. In 1967 he said, "In a sense, you could say we're not even using socialism. We used capitalism in the extreme—the most wasteful nation in the world," and then, "Something is wrong with capitalism... the profit motive alone is not adequate to meet the needs of every member of the society." This is subversive. This is the King evangelicals have had to erase.

He was also deeply critical of American militarism. His 1967 sermon "Beyond Vietnam," delivered a year before his

If the real King had lived another decade, what would he have demanded? Would he have marched against American military presence around the world, mobilized for reparations, built international solidarity with liberation movements? We cannot know, because he was assassinated; we can only infer from the direction he was moving.

The tragedy is that King's radicalism was necessary in 1967 and remains necessary in 2026. The American system still produces poverty. The American military is still involved in endless wars. American capitalism still produces inequality that is obscene. If King were alive today, he would not be celebrating our progress; he would be asking why we still have poverty in the richest nation on earth, why we still spend a trillion dollars a year on the military while children go hungry. He would be calling American evangelicalism to account—asking how it can claim to follow Jesus while defending systems that exploit, how it can claim to believe the gospel while defending a capitalism that produces poverty. This is why white evangelicals have had to domesticate him. The real King is too threatening. The real King demands too much.

## **CORPORATE SIN FROM ACHAN TO THE PROPHETS**

is conquering Canaan. Jericho falls, but the assault on the next city, Ai, goes wrong: the soldiers are defeated, and though fewer than forty men die, the loss is shocking because it is unexpected. Joshua, confused and angry, asks God what happened, and the answer is specific. Someone has violated the covenant. A man named Achan has taken a cloak, silver, and gold from Jericho—things devoted entirely to God.

What happens next is what makes American readers uncomfortable. Achan is found out, and it is not Achan alone who is executed: his sons, his daughters, his animals, everything he has. The whole household is killed for his sin. To modern American sensibilities this is deeply offensive, because we hold a concept called individual responsibility—Achan's sin is Achan's sin, and his family should not bear it. Yet Joshua understood something we have lost: Achan is not an individual but a member of a family, and his sin is corporate; the entire household is implicated.

This is not unique to Joshua. The book of Exodus speaks of consequences reaching the third and fourth generations.

*I, the Lord your God, am a jealous God, punishing the children for the sin of the parents to the third and fourth generation.*

EXODUS 34:7

**THIS IS NOT ABOUT** individual guilt; it is about how sin works structurally. When a father steals and builds wealth on the theft, the children who did not steal still inherit—and so are implicated. When a nation enslaves people and builds its economy on slavery, the next generation does not enslave anyone, but it inherits the wealth that slavery

The prophets understood this. When Amos declares, "For three sins of Israel, even for four, I will not relent," he is not naming individual sins but the sins of a nation, the sins of Israel as a people. Isaiah tells the nation, "Your hands are full of blood"—indicting not only the individuals who committed violence but the nation that allowed and benefited from it. Micah says to the leaders of Jacob, "You eat the flesh of my people and tear away their skin," naming a whole system that consumes people.

The prophetic tradition grasps corporate sin in a way American individualism cannot. American individualism says each person is responsible for their own actions, and if you personally did not commit the sin, you are not guilty. Scripture says something different: that you benefit from sinful systems, that you belong to a people perpetuating injustice, that you inherit the consequences of what your ancestors did—and that this is true not only spiritually but materially. White America inherited wealth built on slavery; it lives in neighborhoods shaped by redlining; it benefits from an educational system in which schools in white neighborhoods receive more resources than schools in Black ones. This is not individual virtue or vice. It is structural.

American Christianity, having absorbed American individualism, cannot process the prophetic understanding of corporate sin. When a Christian says, "I did not personally own slaves, so I am not guilty," he is reasoning from American individualism, not biblical logic. The biblical logic runs differently: "I benefit from systems built through slavery. I am part of a nation that perpetuates segregation. I inherit the consequences. What do I do about that?" This is the category

## REDLINING, THE GI BILL, AND THE RACIAL WEALTH GAP

**REDLINING IS NOT ANCIENT** history. It was the explicit policy of the Federal Housing Administration to refuse to insure mortgages in neighborhoods with Black residents. The FHA drew maps; the maps drew red lines around neighborhoods with Black people; those red lines meant "hazardous," and hazardous meant the government would not insure mortgages there. This was not an accident or a market force. It was government policy—a systematic exclusion of Black people from the primary wealth-building mechanism available to Americans in the twentieth century.

White families in other neighborhoods could get FHA-insured mortgages, buy homes, build equity, and pass those homes to their children. Thirty years of mortgage payments created tremendous wealth; a home that cost \$5,000 in 1945 was worth \$150,000 by 1975, and that wealth transferred to the next generation. Black families could not participate. Blocked from the same neighborhoods, the same mortgages, the same wealth-building, they remained renters, unable to build home equity, and they remained poor. The wealth gap between white and Black families is not the product of white people being more hardworking or more responsible; it exists

The church was implicated. White churches sat in the all-white neighborhoods that redlining preserved, benefiting from stable property values, building their buildings in places they knew would stay white and prosperous. Black churches sat in the redlined neighborhoods the government had marked hazardous—the ones where no one would invest, where property deteriorated and people stayed poor.

The GI Bill is another example. After World War II, the federal government offered education and mortgage benefits to veterans, presented as an opportunity for all Americans, but distributed unequally in practice. Universities in the South refused to admit Black students, so Black veterans could not use their education benefits there; Northern universities admitted them, but housing segregation meant they could not live where white students lived, and discrimination limited where they could settle afterward. Mortgage benefits were available to Black veterans on paper, but mortgage discrimination meant banks and sellers would not sell to them, so the benefit stayed theoretical. The GI Bill created a generation of home-owning, educated white Americans; the same benefits, offered to Black veterans, were implemented in ways that excluded them. White wealth increased dramatically. Black wealth did not increase proportionally.

Again, this is not individual choice but policy—systems that look neutral, a benefit available to all veterans, that function to exclude on the basis of race. These are the facts that CRT names accurately, the policies that created the wealth gap, the structures that remain in place because no

## READING SCRIPTURE FROM BELOW: KING'S HERMENEUTIC

**KING'S THEOLOGICAL METHOD DIFFERED** from white evangelical theology. King read Scripture against culture, asking what Scripture was saying to the situation he and his people faced right now. White evangelical theology tends instead to read Scripture as timeless truth applied universally, asking what a text teaches about doctrine or individual spirituality. King asked what Scripture was saying to people who are oppressed—what Exodus teaches enslaved people, what the prophetic tradition teaches people being crushed by injustice. This is a hermeneutics of resistance, reading Scripture from below, from the vantage of the oppressed, asking what it has to say to them.

When King read "Let my people go," he heard God speaking to enslaved people in America; when he read the



This is why white evangelical theology missed what King saw: it could not read Scripture as liberation because its theologians were not living in oppression but defending the system rather than resisting it. The Black church kept a different hermeneutic, reading Scripture as liberation literature because it was living the reality of oppression. This hermeneutical difference is not a side issue. It is fundamental to what it means to read Scripture faithfully.

The Black church in the civil rights movement was not prophetic because its preachers decided to be political. It was prophetic because it read Scripture as the word of God spoken to its condition. When Black preachers read Exodus, they were not reading ancient history but their own liberation; when they read the prophets, they were not reading abstract theology but God's judgment on the systems oppressing their people. This was not an unusual reading. It is how the oppressed have always read Scripture—the

This is why the gap between prophetic witness and institutional power matters. A prophet is rarely comfortable inside the institution; a prophet challenges it and calls it to account. But a person determined to keep his position within an institution rarely becomes a prophet—he learns to speak in ways that do not threaten power. That is what happened to white evangelicalism: as it gained platforms, influence, and money, it lost its prophetic edge. The Black church kept that edge because it was never in institutional power; it could not afford to domesticate the gospel; it had to read Scripture as a word about liberation because it needed liberation.

What would it take for the American church to recover prophetic witness? A willingness to lose institutional power—leaders willing to speak prophetically even if it costs them their platform, their income, their influence. Most institutional leaders will not do this; they have too much invested in maintaining the institution. But some pastors and leaders are willing, and though they often face opposition from institutional leaders and lose position and influence, they keep their credibility. They sound like the prophets of Scripture, like people speaking truth to power. This is what the American church needs—not more leaders managing the conversation, but prophetic voices willing to challenge the institution even at the cost of their position.

Naming systemic injustice means naming the persons

Addressing systemic racism requires rejecting that way of seeing—recognizing the oppressed as fully human, fully capable, fully worthy of dignity, and then asking: if this person is fully human and fully capable, why are they poor? The answer cannot be that they are lazy. The answer must be that the system deliberately excludes them, that the system is rigged. This is where individual solutions fail. "Work harder, educate yourself, pull yourself up by your bootstraps" cannot work if the system is designed to exclude you no matter what you do. A Black person can be as educated as a white person and still face discrimination in hiring, can work as hard and still remain poor, can do everything right and still be denied the opportunities given to a white person who does less. Only systemic solutions can address what the system has created—and that is what corporate repentance requires: that those who have benefited acknowledge what the system has done and work to dismantle it, and that those who have been harmed be recognized as fully human and have the system changed for their good.

A purely materialist response would say: provide resources, redistribute wealth, and the problem is solved. The gospel knows that is not enough. It knows that the oppressed need healing, that those who have oppressed others need forgiveness and transformation, that reconciliation requires more than economic justice. This is why the cross matters. The cross is God's response to systemic injustice—not only to individual sin, but God standing with the oppressed, refusing to accept that the execution of the innocent is justified. And the cross is also about redemption: the possibility that even those who maintain systems of oppression can be redeemed, that enemies can become family. A purely secular structure cannot offer this. It can identify the problem. Only the gospel can offer transformation.

In the law of Moses, jubilee was mandated. Every fiftieth year, land returned to its original owners, debts were

Modern American Christianity has largely ignored jubilee. We do not preach it, do not think about it, have erased it from the theological imagination—because jubilee is incompatible with capitalism. It requires regular redistribution of wealth, requires that some people give wealth up, requires limiting the ability of the rich to accumulate. American Christianity has aligned with capitalism, teaching that the accumulation of wealth is virtuous, that the rich deserve their wealth because they worked hard, that redistribution is theft. This is anti-jubilee at its core. It is anti-biblical at its core.

What would a modern jubilee look like? It would look like reparations, like education funding for communities that have been disinvested, like healthcare access for communities that have been neglected, like wealth transferred from the wealthy to those who have been robbed. It would cost something: the wealthy would lose some wealth, the comfortable would become less comfortable. It would also mean that inequality decreases, that a child born into poverty

What would it look like for the American church to recover jubilee? It would look like churches giving away resources, funding Black institutions, redistributing wealth to repair what was stolen. It would look like churches resisting capitalism—saying, we will not accumulate wealth, we will distribute what we have, we will practice jubilee. This is what would make the American church prophetic: not just talking about justice, but practicing it, actually redistributing. Most churches are not willing. Most churches like their wealth and have no interest in jubilee. But this is what Scripture requires. This is what God mandates. This is the test of whether the American church actually believes the Bible—or just likes the parts that do not cost anything.

### EXPANSIONS 3

## Chapters 7-9

*The limits of CRT, the roots of evangelical politics, and  
the two religions of slavery*

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*Knowledge, on this view, is no longer  
about truth. It is about identity.*

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### STANDPOINT EPISTEMOLOGY AND THE RISK OF ESSENTIALIZING RACE

**STANDPOINT EPISTEMOLOGY IS THE** claim that people who have experienced oppression understand how oppression works more accurately than people who have not. Part of this is plainly true; lived experience is valuable, and a person refused a mortgage because of race knows something about housing discrimination that no column of statistics can convey.

The deeper trouble is this: if only the oppressed can speak, we have conceded that knowledge is not about truth but about identity — about who you are rather than what you know. That is not a structure for finding truth. It is a structure for managing power. CRT in its academic form is more careful here; Derrick Bell and Kimberlé Crenshaw both acknowledged that people outside a group can understand the systems that oppress that group. Their claim was epistemological — that we should value listening to those who have experienced oppression — not a claim that no one else can understand. In popular application, however, standpoint epistemology gets weaponized: if you are white, your voice does not matter on race; if you are a man, your voice does not matter on gender. The result is that genuine dialogue stops, and the very people who have benefited from unjust systems are barred from the work of changing them.



## HOW CANCELLATION REPLACES REPENTANCE

**THE THIRD WEAKNESS IS** the absence of grace and redemption. CRT is good at naming what went wrong and at analyzing how systems perpetuate injustice; it has far less to say about what happens after the analysis. In some applications, especially in activist spaces shaped by CRT, the response to racism has become cancellation. A person says the wrong thing, their past statements are scrutinized, their career ends — on the assumption that the person is irredeemable, that they cannot change, that the only response is removal.

This is where CRT-influenced activism parts ways with the gospel. The gospel assumes that people can change, that confession and repentance are possible, that someone who

The prophetic tradition in Scripture works differently. The prophets judge. They condemn systems and the people who maintain them. But they also offer repentance: you can change, you can turn, you can take part in a different future. Jonah is the extreme case — he does not want Nineveh to repent, he wants Nineveh destroyed — and yet God offers Nineveh repentance, the city repents, the city is saved, and Jonah is left angry that God is merciful. That is the tension Scripture holds: God judges, and God offers redemption; God condemns systems, and God calls people to abandon those systems and join the new thing he is doing. Some CRT-influenced activism loses this and becomes purely judgmental — purity tests and calling out, making sure you are on the right side of the analysis — until it stops being about actually changing systems at all. CRT can tell you what is wrong. The gospel can tell you how to fix it, and how to change as a person in the process.

The prophets, in fact, offer a model that goes beyond both pure condemnation and cheap reconciliation. They named injustice ferociously and condemned the leaders of Israel without hesitation, yet they also held out a path forward that included redemption. Jeremiah is the difficult case. He preached that Jerusalem should surrender to Babylon — not a popular message, not one that made him beloved. The people wanted him to prophesy victory; he prophesied defeat. Why

Ezekiel gives another version. He sees Jerusalem destroyed — the Temple burned, the people scattered, the city emptied — and it is devastating; then he sees a vision of restoration, the dry bones coming alive, the Temple rebuilt, the people returning, the city renewed. Judgment is real and its consequences are real, but it is not the end of the story. This differs from CRT-informed activism that sees judgment and has no structure for restoration, and it differs just as sharply from white evangelicalism that sees judgment and forgives at once without requiring any change. The prophetic structure says judgment is necessary — the system has to be exposed as unjust, the people who maintain it have to face what they have done — but judgment is not the goal. Restoration is the goal; judgment is the means that makes restoration possible. Practically, that means when we expose systemic racism we are not chiefly interested in condemning white people but in transforming the system so it no longer perpetuates injustice, and in white people joining that work — though the work requires first acknowledging what the system has done and the benefit one has received from it. Not cancellation. Not absolution. Accountability that leads to change.

## **SEGREGATION ACADEMIES AND THE SOUTHERN STRATEGY**

Liberty University in 1971. The date matters. This is after desegregation, after the Civil Rights Act of 1964, in the very moment integration was being forced onto American institutions. Liberty was founded as a segregation academy — founded so that white Christian families could educate their children without their attending integrated schools. Falwell was explicit. He said he was concerned about what secular universities were teaching, about the moral decline of America, and he framed it as building a Christian university where children would be educated in a Christian environment. But that environment was a segregated one. He did not accept Black students at Liberty until 1971, when federal pressure forced him to, and even then he discouraged Black enrollment.

Bob Jones University is the clearer example. BJU was founded in 1927 as a Bible college, and by the 1950s it was explicit: the university forbade interracial dating. Not implicit, not suggested — an explicit, stated rule, no dating between races. Why? BJU claimed it was biblical, that God made the races distinct and intended them to remain separate, that interracial dating violated God's design. The rule stayed in place until 2000. Two thousand. Not 1960. Not 1970. And when it was finally removed, it was removed quietly, with minimal acknowledgment. Consider what that means: a Christian university explicitly forbade young people of different races from dating on biblical grounds, enforced segregation on personal relationships, and kept the rule for forty years after the Civil Rights Act.

And evangelicals acted shocked when outsiders criticized evangelicalism for racism. They pointed to figures like Billy

The Southern Strategy is part of this history. It was the political strategy Republicans adopted in the 1960s and 1970s: if you want Southern votes, you do not have to say you support segregation explicitly — you use coded language. You talk about law and order. You talk about states' rights. You talk about traditional values. You never mention race, but the message to Southern white voters is clear: we will defend your way of life against the changes coming. Evangelicals embraced it. Leaders like Falwell shifted from being apolitical or Democratic to being Republican precisely because the Republican Party was using language that signaled opposition to integration without saying it. This is the origin of the evangelical-Republican alliance — and it came not from abortion but from resistance to integration. The Moral Majority, which Falwell founded in 1979, was presented as a response to moral decline and secular humanism; but the timing is telling. It was founded after desegregation had been forced on the country, and it gave evangelicals a way to organize politically against the changes they opposed. Abortion was part of the coalition. The core energy, the organizing principle, was resistance to the loss of white evangelical cultural dominance. Once you grasp this history, you understand why white evangelicalism has been so resistant to racial justice, why it panics when race comes up, why it attacks CRT so viciously: CRT names exactly what white evangelicalism has been defending for fifty years.

What would it look like to teach racial justice history in evangelical institutions? It would mean that every seminarian learns the history of the church's complicity in slavery and segregation, including the complicity of their own denominations — Southern Baptist Seminary students learning about the SBC's defense of slavery, Bob Jones Seminary students learning about the interracial dating ban. It would mean studying the prophetic tradition and

## SLAVE RELIGION VS. SLAVEHOLDER RELIGION

**JAMES CONE WROTE A** book called *The Cross and the Lynching Tree*, and the title is its argument. The cross, the central symbol of Christianity, is the execution of an innocent person by an unjust state. The lynching tree, the central image of American racial terrorism, is also the execution of an innocent person by a racist mob. Cone is saying these are the same thing: both are executions, both the killing of the powerless by the powerful, both acts of violence meant to maintain hierarchy, both supposedly justified as necessary, both claiming some moral legitimacy.

Christianity has traditionally read the cross as redemption — the death of Jesus purchasing salvation. Cone asks what it would mean to read the cross as lynching, to say that Jesus was lynched, executed by a mob that had the law's approval, an innocent person murdered to keep a power structure in place. If Jesus was lynched, then the cross is not primarily

Frederick Douglass wrote something similar. An enslaved man who escaped and became an abolitionist, he wrote an essay called *The Slaveholder's Sermon*, contrasting the religion of the slave with the religion of the slaveholder. The slave's religion was about God's liberation — about Exodus, about freedom; the enslaved gathered in secret and sang about getting to the promised land, about freedom by and by, about a God who sees the enslaved and will act. The slaveholder's religion was about obedience — the slaveholder preached to the enslaved to obey their masters, honor their masters, accept their condition, and took Scripture and used it to justify slavery, building theology to defend the indefensible. These are not two interpretations of the same Christianity. They are two different religions. They share the same book and read it in opposite directions: the slave as a book about liberation, the slaveholder as a book about submission.

Douglass's insight cut deep. The religion taught by the slaveholder would destroy the soul of anyone who believed it; believe the slaveholder's sermon and you accept slavery as legitimate, accept your own oppression, accept the oppression of others. The religion practiced by the enslaved, by contrast, creates freedom — the possibility of resistance,



William Wilberforce complicates the evangelical version of this story. A British politician who came to faith and became convinced slavery was wrong, he spent decades working to abolish it throughout the British Empire and eventually succeeded. Evangelicals point to him as proof that the gospel produces justice: a man converted, convicted by conscience, who changed a system. But the story is more complicated. Wilberforce also supported colonialism; he believed Britain should colonize Africa and India and elsewhere, and he believed that colonization was a civilizing mission, a Christian mission. So he freed people from the direct institution of slavery while supporting systems that kept

This is how systems maintain themselves. Individuals work for change in one area while remaining blind to injustice in another, and the system adapts — it gives up slavery but keeps colonialism, gives up segregation but keeps redlining. Personal conversion, then, is necessary but insufficient. A white pastor whose conscience is awakened about racism and who decides to pastor differently is doing something good; but if the church still benefits from segregated neighborhoods, from property purchased through redlining, from wealth accumulated by excluding Black people, his individual conversion does not solve the systemic problem. Real change requires structural transformation — churches that built wealth through segregation actually redistributing it to repair what they damaged, seminaries that trained pastors to defend segregation actually teaching a different history, denominations that maintained segregation taking concrete steps to become genuinely multiethnic. Personal conversion is the beginning. It cannot be the end. The system has to change, and the people within it have to be willing to pay a cost to change it.

There is one more paradox in this inheritance, and it concerns the Book itself. White evangelicalism prides itself on biblical literacy; its pastors study Greek and Hebrew, its

The Black church has always understood this, reading Scripture as a living word, as God speaking to their condition, asking what God is saying to us in our situation. White evangelicalism has read Scripture as a collection of doctrines and principles, asking what a text teaches about theology or individual spirituality. Those are not bad questions, but they are not the primary one. The primary question is what God is saying about justice, about the vulnerable, about the systems we participate in. White evangelical literacy has produced pastors who can explain the theology of atonement without asking whether they are complicit in the systems that require atonement, scholars who can defend the authority of Scripture while resisting what Scripture actually says about justice. To read Scripture as the oppressed read it would mean beginning with the recognition that I do not stand above the text as an objective analyzer — I am inside it, it is

## **HOLDING GRACE AND JUSTICE TOGETHER AT THE CROSS**

**AMERICAN EVANGELICALISM HAS EMPHASIZED** grace. It preaches that all are sinners, all have fallen short, all are justified by faith in Christ alone — and this is true. But American evangelicalism has often used grace to avoid justice. If everyone is a sinner, then no one is uniquely culpable; if everyone needs grace, then no one specifically needs to repent of perpetuating injustice; if God forgives all, then we can move on without addressing what was done. This is grace distorted into sentimentalism — grace that costs nothing and changes nothing. Its danger is that

But there is an opposite error: justice without grace. If the whole focus falls on naming systems and condemning the people who maintain them, with no possibility of redemption or transformation, then justice becomes despair. Justice without grace says: you have benefited from injustice, and therefore you are irredeemable; the system is too broken, and there is no point in trying to change it. That is a justice that has lost hope.

What does the cross offer? Both at once. The cross is God's judgment on injustice — the execution of the innocent is inexcusable, and God refuses to accept it — and it is God's grief over what humans have done to each other. But it is also God's offer of redemption, God saying: you have done terrible things, and they matter, the consequences are real, but there is a way forward, there is forgiveness, there is transformation. Grace-without-justice says it does not matter what you did, you are forgiven, move on. Justice-without-grace says what you did matters so much that you can never be forgiven, you are condemned forever. The cross says what you did matters immensely, the consequences are real, the people you harmed deserve restitution — and you can change, you can repent, you can join the work of transformation; your guilt does not have to define you forever.

This is the message the American church needs to recover. Not grace that avoids justice. Not justice that avoids grace. Both, simultaneously. In a church pursuing racial justice it would mean that people who have benefited from systems of injustice are not absolved without repentance — no saying I

IS CRITICAL RACE THEORY BIBLICAL?

## EXPANSIONS 4

# Chapters 10–12 and Conclusion

*Truth and reconciliation, the practical theology of  
reparations, and the cost of discipleship*

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*Cheap reconciliation costs nothing.  
Genuine reconciliation costs  
everything.*

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## THE TRUTH AND RECONCILIATION MODEL AND A CHURCH'S APOLOGY

**WHEN APARTHEID ENDED, SOUTH** Africa faced a choice between retribution and reconciliation. The country could have hunted down every person involved in apartheid

This was not cheap grace. It required the perpetrator to face the person they had harmed, to speak the truth about what they had done, to stand in vulnerability and exposure. For the victim, it meant hearing the confession, getting a chance to speak, and receiving public acknowledgment that what happened was real and was wrong. Some perpetrators refused to confess and faced prosecution; some victims could not accept the confession even when it was offered, and sought prosecution instead. But the structure was clear: truth first, then reconciliation — justice through acknowledgment and change, not through retribution.

What would an American version look like? Imagine evangelical leaders going to Black churches and saying plainly: here is what we did. We defended slavery, created segregation academies, remained silent during violence, built wealth from systems of injustice, and taught theology that justified oppression. We did this. We benefited. We have not changed. Now what — what would reconciliation require?

Briarwood Presbyterian Church in Birmingham, Alabama offers a small example. Founded in 1971 in explicit response to desegregation, Briarwood came into being when parents pulled their children out of integrated public schools to maintain segregation. In 2021, the church's pastor stood up



## THE PRACTICAL THEOLOGY OF REPARATIONS: REPAIR, NOT CHARITY

**ACKNOWLEDGMENT IS ONLY THE** beginning of reconciliation; the question that follows is what to do about it, and this is where reparations enter. Reparations is not about money — it is about structural change, about the perpetrator attempting to repair what was broken. If Briarwood was founded to benefit white families by allowing them to escape integration, then reparations from Briarwood might mean financially supporting integrated public schools, committing a percentage of its budget to schools in historically Black neighborhoods, and working to actually become integrated, not just in membership but in decision-making power. If churches benefited from slavery and segregation, then reparations from those churches might mean funding Black churches, closing the wealth gap between white and Black congregations, and redistributing power and resources.

Reparations is a confusing concept for white evangelicals because evangelicals have been taught that justice is about individual guilt and forgiveness. From that vantage, reparations make no sense: if I personally did not enslave anyone, why should I pay, and if a Black person in my church was never enslaved, why would they receive anything? But

The practical theology runs in four movements. First, acknowledge what was taken — slavery extracted trillions of dollars of labor from African Americans, segregation extracted opportunity and resources and dignity, redlining extracted the very ability to build wealth; these were massive systemic extractions, not small harms. Second, acknowledge the ongoing benefit: white Americans have benefited from this extraction whether they intended to or not, because white neighborhoods exist on account of redlining that excluded Black people, white schools received resources because segregated funding favored them, and white wealth accumulated because slavery was free labor and segregation prevented Black families from accumulating any. Third, acknowledge that the harm continues — the effects of slavery, segregation, and redlining are not historical but current, experienced by anyone born into a segregated neighborhood, into a family with less wealth, into a community with fewer resources. Fourth, recognize that repair is necessary; repair is not charity, not feeling sorry, but systematic restitution for what was taken.

What might this look like at a church level? A church located in a neighborhood preserved through redlining, benefiting from property values kept stable because Black people were excluded, could acknowledge the history explicitly — "Our church building is located on a street that was preserved as all-white through FHA redlining. This exclusion created stable property values for white homeowners and prevented wealth accumulation by Black

Most churches will not do this, because most churches prefer charity. Charity allows the giver to feel good, requires no structural change, and demands no shift in power. Reparations requires all of it — that you acknowledge what you did, pay what you owe, and change the systems that perpetuated the harm. This is what justice requires. This is what the gospel requires. This is the work that would make the American church prophetic and credible. Not: let's move forward and not talk about the past. But: let's acknowledge what happened, understand what it cost, and change the systems that benefited from it. This is costly — which is exactly why cheap reconciliation is so appealing.

## **BUILDING MULTIETHNIC CHURCHES WITHOUT TOKENIZING**

**A WHITE PASTOR CAN** preach a sermon series called "Justice and Reconciliation" without changing anything about the church. The preaching can be eloquent, the condemnation of systemic racism sincere, the call to action stirring — and then the budget stays the same, the

One structure is a cross-racial pastoral partnership: a white pastor and a Black pastor sharing leadership — not a Black assistant under a white senior pastor, but actual shared preaching and shared decision-making power. This is uncomfortable, because it requires the white pastor to relinquish control, to accept that their perspective is not the only one that matters, to be challenged. It also requires the denomination or board to value the partnership enough to hire and pay equally; if the Black pastor is always the assistant, always paid less, always holding less authority, then it is not a partnership at all.

Budget tells the truth about priorities. A church that says it values justice but allocates two percent of its budget to justice work and fifty percent to building maintenance has revealed its real priorities in its ledger. Allocating resources to justice might mean directing fifteen to twenty percent of the annual budget to racial justice work, funding Black churches in the community, supporting Black pastors through education and mentorship, investing in historically disinvested neighborhoods, and paying diverse staff equally and generously. This is not charity. This is repair. This is the attempt to restore what was taken.

Hiring practices reveal who a church actually values. A church that claims to value diversity while its hiring process remains all-white gatekeeping — where only people who look, sound, and think like the current leadership get hired — is not

Building a multiethnic church without tokenizing is the hardest work. Tokenizing is when a church brings in a few people of color, features them prominently in marketing, and keeps them excluded from real power — the church gets to call itself diverse while maintaining white control. Genuine multiethnic community means people of color in leadership, including senior leadership; worship that reflects diverse traditions rather than white evangelical style with a few gospel songs added; music and preaching from diverse perspectives; children's and youth ministry that reflects diverse representation; small groups and fellowship that intentionally cross racial lines; and the clarity that this is not a program but who we are.

There is one more layer, and it is the sharpest. A church that is actually committed to justice will need to be willing to lose members. Some white members will leave if they perceive the church as too political, too focused on race, too willing to challenge the status quo; that is the cost. But keep those members and you sacrifice the possibility of genuine multiethnic community — you remain segregated, you remain comfortable. A church serious about justice has to choose. You choose either comfort or integrity.

## **INSTITUTIONALIZING JUSTICE BEYOND THE SERMON SERIES**

to pursue racial justice begin with a sermon series or a study or a statement — something visible, something that can be pointed to as evidence of commitment. But a sermon series is not a system; a sermon series is words, and systems are what remain after the series ends. So how do you know whether your church is actually committed to justice or merely performing it? You look at the budget, because the budget never lies and tells you what a church actually values. A church that claims commitment to racial justice but spends two percent on justice work and seventy percent on building maintenance has been answered by its own ledger; a church that claims commitment to diversity but pays white staff better than Black staff has been answered by its payroll; a church that claims commitment to community but does nothing to repair the neighborhoods where Black members live has been answered by its inaction.

Institutionalizing justice means building systems that survive the sermon series — systems that remain when the pastor who preached about justice leaves, systems that continue when the cultural moment shifts. In practice that means several things. First, a racial equity committee with actual power — not one that meets monthly to discuss equity while real authority stays with white leadership, but a committee with decision-making power over hiring, budget allocation, and strategic direction. Second, measurable goals with accountability — not vague commitments to "become more diverse" but specifics: by 2028, twenty-five percent of leadership positions held by people of color; by 2030, a budget reflecting a twenty percent allocation to justice work; by 2027, an established reparations fund with a set amount

This is what institutionalization looks like, and it is not comfortable; it requires resources, and it requires power to actually shift. The hard truth is that most churches are not willing to do it. Most churches want the prophetic witness without the structural cost, want to say they care about justice without actually changing. Until churches are willing to institutionalize justice, the work will not happen.

## **THE COST OF DISCIPLESHIP AND THE NEXT GENERATION**

**A WHITE PASTOR WHO** leads a church toward racial justice will face real resistance — from members who leave, from other pastors who question his commitment to Scripture, from denominational pressure. The pastor has to be willing to pay that cost, not out of a martyr complex but out of a realistic understanding that if you challenge comfortable Christianity, comfortable Christianity will push back. He will also face pressure from Black members and Black community leaders to go deeper, to do more, to cost more — and they will be right;

A pastor serious about this will need community: a pastors' group or a coaching relationship with others doing similar work, accountability, and the willingness to be challenged especially by Black pastors so that he does not slide back into comfort. He will need to be willing to be taught — to read Black theologians, to listen to the concerns of Black members without defensiveness, to be wrong about things he thought he understood. This is demanding work that white evangelical culture does not support; that culture rewards pastors who build big churches, hold a platform, and become thought leaders, not pastors who challenge white evangelicalism itself. But this is the work. This is what it means to take the gospel seriously.

What sustains a pastor in this work is the knowledge that it is true — that what the prophets say is true, that what James Cone says is true, that what the Black church has known all along is true. The gospel is bigger than white evangelicalism; it is not captive to white evangelical culture; it breaks free from every culture that tries to claim it and stands in judgment over every human system. A pastor who really believes this will be willing to lead his church in this direction, whatever the cost.

And the next generation is watching. What are we telling young Christians about the gospel when we preach about justice on Sunday and stay silent about injustice in our community on Monday? What are we telling them about integrity when we say racism is wrong but defend every system that perpetuates it? What are we telling them about the truthfulness of Scripture when we refuse to let Scripture speak to the most visible injustice in our country? Young



The institutional church is hemorrhaging young Christians, and the reason is not that Christianity is false; the reason is that institutional Christianity has become comfortable with injustice in a way they find impossible to stomach. They do not want to belong to a religion comfortable with injustice, a religion that claims to love Jesus but refuses to do what Jesus did — stand with the vulnerable, challenge the powerful, announce good news to the poor. If the church is to have a future with them, it has to change: to challenge the systems that oppress rather than defend them, to stand with the vulnerable rather than the powerful, to be willing to cost something. This is not about being hip or relevant. This is about being faithful.

Bonhoeffer wrote about the cost of discipleship from inside Nazi Germany, watching the German church collaborate with Nazi ideology, writing to pastors who wanted to follow Jesus in a context of totalitarian evil. His point was that discipleship costs something — that it is not about personal salvation but about following Jesus into conflict with the systems of power. The American church has largely lost this understanding. American evangelicalism preaches that following Jesus leads to blessing: follow Jesus and you will be happy, your life will improve, you will have peace. This is a prosperity gospel, a gospel domesticated and adapted to fit

But the gospel Jesus preached was not a gospel of blessing; it was a gospel of challenge.

*If anyone would come after me, let him deny himself  
and take up his cross and follow me.*

MARK 8:34

**THE CROSS IS NOT** a metaphor. The cross is death. The cross is what happens to people who challenge power.

*Blessed are you when others revile you and persecute you  
and utter all kinds of evil against you falsely on my  
account.*

MATTHEW 5:11

**JESUS DID NOT SAY:** follow me and you will be successful. He said: follow me and you will face opposition, follow me and you will be persecuted, follow me and you might die. In the context of systemic injustice this means that discipleship includes challenging unjust systems, standing with the vulnerable, and accepting the cost of opposition. A pastor who challenges his denomination's complicity in racism will face opposition; a pastor who leads his church toward justice will lose members; a pastor who redistributes resources will face criticism from wealthy donors. This is the cost of discipleship — what following Jesus looks like where power structures are invested in the status quo.

The American church has avoided this cost, preaching a gospel of comfort and asking how one might follow Jesus in a way that costs nothing. But that is not following Jesus; that is using Jesus as a spiritual comfort object, making him a

The choice is before the American church now. A pastor has to choose: am I going to lead my church toward comfort or toward faithfulness; am I going to defend the systems we have benefited from, or work toward their undoing? These are not complicated questions, and the answers are clear. What is unclear is whether pastors will have the courage to live out the answers.

EXPANSIONS 5

# Second Round Expansions for Chapters 3, 5, 9

*The lynching era, the prophets on worship and justice,  
and reading Scripture as the oppressed do*

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*Trust has to be earned. Trust requires  
that white Christianity demonstrate a  
fundamental change, not just in  
words, but in action and in structure.*

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THE LYNCHING ERA AND THE CHURCH'S  
COMPLICITY

approximately 4,400 people were lynched in America. This is not a guess; it is documented, part of the historical record. They were Black people, mostly Black men, killed by mobs that often acted with the knowledge and complicity of local law enforcement. Lynching was terrorism, a system of control used to keep Black people in subordination, to punish any attempt at equality, and to maintain white dominance through fear.

What was the church's response? In many cases, the church was complicit. The lynch mob met at the church; the lynch mob included church members; the church remained silent, did not protect its members, and did not speak prophetically against the violence. In some cases the church actively participated, with ministers among the mob and congregations hosting the gatherings that planned the killing. In still other cases the church offered theological cover, preaching law and order, obedience to authorities, and acceptance of God's providence. It was the same sermon Frederick Douglass had identified a century before: the slaveholder's sermon, the one that taught acceptance and submission.

One case crystallizes all of it. Emmett Till was a fourteen-year-old boy from Chicago whose family sent him to Mississippi to visit relatives in the summer of 1955. He allegedly whistled at a white woman; a white man and the woman's husband kidnapped him, tortured him, and murdered him, putting a cotton gin fan around his neck before throwing his body in the river. When his body was recovered, his mother did something that became historic — she demanded an open casket so the world could see what

And where was the church? The white churches of Mississippi and the South did not march, did not demand justice, did not even speak. An all-white Mississippi jury acquitted the murderers, and the white churches accepted the verdict. This happened in 1955. This is living memory, recent history, not something distant we can hold at arm's length.

Here is the connection to present distrust. Black people remember; Black families tell these stories; Black churches keep this history alive in a way white churches do not. So when white Christianity now says it is willing to address racial justice, Black people remember a white Christianity willing to ignore murder. When white Christianity now says it values reconciliation, Black people remember a white Christianity willing to accept injustice. When white Christianity now says it believes all people bear the image of God, Black people remember a white Christianity willing to sacrifice Black children. This is not about holding grudges. It is about understanding that trust has to be earned, has to be built, and requires that white Christianity demonstrate a fundamental change — not just in words, but in action and in structure.

The lynching era is not past. The brutality against Black people continues; it simply uses different methods — police violence, mass incarceration, healthcare disparities, educational disparities. The system of control continues, and so, often, does the church's silence. Until the American

## WORSHIP WITHOUT JUSTICE: AMOS 5, ISAIAH 58, MICAH 6, JAMES 2

**AMOS 5 IS GOD** speaking to Israel, and it is the most devastating indictment of worship in Scripture.

*I hate, I despise your religious festivals; your assemblies are a stench to me. Even though you bring me burnt offerings and grain offerings, I will not accept them... But let justice roll on like a river, righteousness like a never-failing stream!*

AMOS 5:21-24

**GOD IS SAYING THAT** the festivals disgust him, that the offerings are worthless to him — but that if Israel lets justice roll on like a river, he will receive them. The point is clear: worship without justice is not worship. Worship that does not lead to justice is an insult to God. He does not want their songs; he wants them to dismantle systems of oppression.

Isaiah 58 carries the same message to people who were fasting and could not understand why God seemed unmoved.

*Is not this the kind of fasting I have chosen: to loose the chains of injustice and untie the cords of the yoke, to set the oppressed free and break every yoke? Is it not to share your food with the hungry and to provide the poor wanderer with shelter?*

ISAIAH 58:6-7

justice is not religious practice; fasting that does not work for justice is meaningless. God says he does not want their religious discipline — he wants them to work for justice. Micah 6:8 is the summary of the whole prophetic demand.

*He has shown you, O mortal, what is good. And what does the Lord require of you? To act justly and to love mercy and to walk humbly with your God.*

MICAH 6:8

**THREE THINGS: ACT JUSTLY**, love mercy, walk humbly. Not believe correctly. Not hold the right theology. Act justly — this is about what you do, not merely what you affirm. James carries the same tradition forward into the New Testament, speaking specifically about faith and poverty: "Faith by itself, if it is not accompanied by action, is dead" (James 2:17). If you see someone who is poor and do nothing, your faith is dead. Faith requires action; faith requires that you actually do something about injustice.

This is the prophetic tradition, and this is what Scripture teaches. Religious practice without justice is not religious; faith without works is dead. American Christianity has largely ignored this. It has made faith about belief, separated faith from justice, and created a Christianity in which a person can believe correctly and maintain injustice at the same time. The prophets will not allow it. The prophets say that if you are not working for justice, your worship is an abomination.

## **JESUS AND THE DISINHERITED: HOWARD THURMAN'S READING**

**HOWARD THURMAN, A BLACK** theologian and pastor,



When Jesus said "Blessed are the poor," Thurman observes, he was speaking to people who were actually poor; when he said "Blessed are those who hunger," he was speaking to people who were actually hungry. He was not speaking metaphorically but to people's material condition. This changes the reading entirely. "Blessed are the poor" is not a mystical saying about spiritual poverty; it is Jesus telling materially poor people that God cares about them, that their poverty does not disqualify them from God's love, that they matter. "Blessed are those who mourn" is not about sadness in general but about people mourning the death of loved ones to violence, mourning the loss of dignity, mourning what the system has done to them. And when Jesus said, "I have come that they may have life, and have it to the full," he was speaking to people whose lives were constrained, whose possibilities were limited, who were treated as less than fully human.

Thurman's point is that white theology, written from a position of power, has domesticated these sayings, turning them into statements about individual spiritual experience rather than material liberation. A white theologian living in comfort can read "blessed are the poor" as a spiritual metaphor; a poor person experiencing actual poverty reads it as Jesus speaking to them directly. This is why white theology

But if you read the gospel as the teaching of an oppressed person to oppressed people, everything changes. Jesus becomes a subversive, a revolutionary, someone telling oppressed people that God is on their side. This is what the Black church understood from the beginning, and it is why the Black church found such power in the gospel — it understood that Jesus was speaking to them, that he understood their condition, that he offered hope not of spiritual comfort within oppression but of oppression overcome. White theology has taken centuries to begin to understand what the Black church has always known.

### **AMERICA'S FOUNDATIONAL LIE AND THE WEALTH GAP**

**AMERICA HAS A FOUNDATIONAL** mythology: that we are a nation built on freedom, on the inalienable rights of all men, on the idea that all people are created equal. This is what we learn in school, the story we tell ourselves. But the history is different. America was built on race-based slavery, founded by people who owned other human beings, its founding documents written by slaveholders who denied the humanity of the enslaved. Thomas Jefferson wrote that "all men are created equal, and are endowed by their Creator with certain unalienable Rights" — and Jefferson owned two hundred enslaved people, raped at least one enslaved woman, and built his entire wealth on enslaved labor. This is not a contradiction that

After slavery ended, America replaced it with segregation, and after segregation was legally ended, America replaced it with systems that maintained racial hierarchy through legal but obviously unjust means: redlining, mass incarceration, educational inequality, healthcare disparities. The mythology says we have overcome our racist past, that we are a nation of progress that learns from its mistakes. The history says America has continually adapted its systems of racial oppression — that when one system becomes untenable, it creates a new one.

Why does this matter for American Christians? Because American Christians have absorbed American mythology. They think of America as a Christian nation founded on Christian values, a nation God favors. But America was not founded on Christian values; it was founded on the enslavement of African people, the genocide of Native Americans, the theft of land and labor. And American Christians were complicit — they did not merely fail to oppose slavery, they created theology to defend it and built churches with its proceeds. Until American Christians can face the actual history of America rather than the mythology, they cannot repent, and without repentance there is no change.

This is what it means to read Scripture against your culture's assumptions, to let the prophets speak. The prophets would say: your nation was built on injustice, your wealth on theft, your comfort on the suffering of others. You have justified this. You have created theology to defend it. You have told a story about your own virtue. But God is not interested in your mythology. God is interested in truth.

Segregation and redlining continued the extraction. White families could use FHA mortgages to build wealth through homeownership; Black families could not. The GI Bill created a generation of white homeowners while Black veterans could not access the same benefits in practice. White wealth compounded; Black wealth did not. By 2024, the median white family holds ten times the wealth of the median Black family — not because white people are better at business or because Black people are lazy, but because of policy, because of systems.

What would reparative justice look like? It would mean that the wealth extracted through slavery and segregation is actually returned, that the government acknowledges the injustice, that repair is attempted. Reparations could look like a direct payment to the descendants of the enslaved, calculated on the wealth extracted. It could look like systematic investment in historically Black communities — educational funding for HBCUs, capital for small businesses in Black neighborhoods, healthcare investment in communities long underserved. And it could look like the church leading the way: acknowledging that it benefited from slavery, that it maintained segregation, and committing to

## INHERITED TRAUMA, THE PSALMS OF LAMENT, AND THE SPIRITUALITY OF RESISTANCE

**WHEN A SYSTEM PERPETUATES** violence against a group for generations, that violence does not disappear when the system officially ends. It transmits across generations through trauma, through memory, through the structures that remain in place. A parent who has experienced racist violence carries that trauma and passes it to their children, who learn to be afraid, learn which places are unsafe, learn that the world is not safe for people who look like them. This is not individual pathology. It is the inheritance of harm.

Research on trauma shows it can be inherited genetically — the nervous system of a person whose ancestors endured sustained violence is shaped by that history, the body knowing fear even when the present individual has not personally experienced what their ancestors did. But trauma is also inherited culturally. A family that survived lynching passes down the knowledge of what white violence can do; a family that experienced redlining passes down a wariness of institutions that made promises but excluded them; a family that experienced mass incarceration passes down the knowledge that the criminal justice system is not just. This

Individual healing is necessary; a person who has inherited trauma needs to process it, to grieve it, to move toward healing. But individual healing is insufficient if the systems that caused the trauma remain in place. A person can heal their individual wound, learn to manage their fear, build a life — and still face the same systems that harmed their parents. This is why corporate repentance is necessary: the institution acknowledging what it did, acknowledging the ongoing harm, and committing to change the systems that perpetuate it. If a denomination had perpetuated segregation, corporate repentance would mean saying, we acknowledge what we did, we acknowledge that the trauma is still affecting people, and we are committing to structural change. If a church had built wealth through redlining, it would mean acknowledging how its building came to be where it is, acknowledging that it benefited from exclusion, and committing resources to repair. If a system of mass incarceration continues to target people of color, it would mean acknowledging the church's silence and committing to challenge that system, to support the incarcerated and their families, to work toward transforming criminal justice. This is repentance at a corporate level — not individual apology, but institutional acknowledgment and institutional change. Without it, the trauma continues, the systems continue, the inheritance of harm continues. This is why the church's work is urgent and why waiting is not an option: the longer the church waits to repent, the longer the trauma transmits to the

The Psalms are the prayer book of the church; for two thousand years Christians have prayed them. But white evangelicalism has largely ignored the psalms of lament. The Psalms are full of lament — "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?"; "How long, O Lord, will you forget me?"; "Out of the depths I cry to you, O Lord" — prayers of people in pain, suffering, asking God why. White evangelical worship has moved away from these psalms, preferring the psalms of praise that celebrate God's power and goodness, wanting songs that make people feel better rather than songs that give voice to their suffering. For Black Christians, the psalms of lament have always been central, giving voice to the experience of oppression: God, you know what is being done to me; God, you see my suffering; God, I cry out to you. The Psalms do not offer comfort so much as something more important — validation. They say your suffering is real, your pain matters, God hears you.

David and Goliath is a story white evangelicalism has read as a tale of individual courage: David is small, Goliath is large, and David's faith in God lets him overcome, so the sermon becomes "you too can overcome your giants." But in the context of Black experience, David and Goliath is a story about the powerless against the powerful. David is empowered not by individual courage but by being on God's side while Goliath stands on the side of oppression, empowered by faith that God is working for justice. When Black Christians read it, they read a promise: God is on the side of the vulnerable, God will fight for the oppressed, and the powers that seem so strong will fall. What does the church lose when it refuses the psalms of lament, when it reads

That recovery has a history. The enslaved in America were forbidden from gathering, forbidden from learning to read, forbidden from worship that did not serve the slaveholder's interests. And yet they gathered in secret and developed a spirituality of resistance — praying in the quarters, singing in ways that sounded like spirituals but carried hidden meaning, believing that God saw them and that liberation was coming. This was not mere comfort; it was defiance. The enslaved who gathered to worship, who sang about freedom, who prayed for deliverance, were committing an act of resistance against the system that claimed ownership of their bodies. The slaveholder understood this and did not want it; the slaveholder wanted a spirituality of acceptance, wanted the enslaved to believe that God intended slavery and that endurance was virtue. That is why he preached his sermon — obey your masters, honor your masters, accept your lot — and tried to control the spiritual lives of those he held. But the enslaved developed a different spirituality, one in which God was a liberator on the side of the vulnerable, in which faith meant resistance to the system. It was not passive. It gave courage, sustained people through incomprehensible



The American church today needs to recover this spirituality and to understand that spirituality is not merely personal peace. It is the deep conviction that God is just, the courage to resist injustice, the hope that another world is possible. This is the spirituality that sustained the civil rights movement, the spirituality of the Black church, the spirituality that white evangelicalism has largely lost. If the American church recovered it — if churches taught their members to understand prayer as an act of resistance, faith as courage to challenge injustice, and hope as the conviction that God's justice will prevail — the American church would be changed. This is spiritual power. This is the kind of faith that changes systems.

EXPANSIONS 6

# Second Round Expansions for Chapters 1, 8, 12

*What CRT is not, the 2020-2024 evangelical panic, and  
the vision of beloved community*

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*If you are going to disagree with  
critical race theory, disagree with  
what it actually says.*

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## WHAT CRT IS NOT: THE STRAW MEN THAT BLOCK ENGAGEMENT

THE MOST COMMON MISREPRESENTATION of critical

Consider an analogy. If you grow up in a house built on stolen land, the house is real, you benefit from living in it, and yet you did not personally steal the land; you are not guilty of theft. But you are benefiting from theft, and you have a choice about what to do with that knowledge. This is not the same as saying you are a racist. It is saying you are benefiting from racism. The two are different claims, and the distortion collapses them — substituting "you are racist" for what CRT actually argues, which is that the systems around you are structured in ways that benefit you because of your race.

The second misrepresentation is that CRT rejects individual agency — that it sees people as purely determined by systems, with no choice and no responsibility. This too is a distortion. Scholars like Derrick Bell and Kimberlé Crenshaw are clear that individuals have agency: people make choices, people resist systems, people work to change them. What CRT adds is that those choices do not happen in a vacuum; they are shaped by the systems a person is in. You can choose to be generous or selfish, but your generosity or selfishness plays out inside arrangements that privilege some and disadvantage others. Some people can choose to be poor and it is read as noble sacrifice; others are poor and it is read as personal failure. The individual choice is the same. The system interprets it differently. The claim is not that you have

The third misrepresentation is that CRT is Marxism — addressed already, but worth naming here for how it shuts down honest engagement. If you decide CRT is Marxism, you decide it is un-American, that it comes from a foreign ideology, that it threatens democracy; and that frame stops you from engaging what CRT says about American systems. But CRT came out of American law schools, developed by American scholars trying to understand American legal history. It is as American as *Brown v. Board of Education*. The Marxism label is useful if your goal is to dismiss CRT without engaging its arguments. It is an obstacle if your goal is to understand them.

The real tragedy is that these misrepresentations have become so dominant that most people who attack CRT are not attacking what it says; they are attacking caricatures of it. That is intellectually dishonest. If you are going to disagree with CRT, disagree with what it actually says. Read Derrick Bell. Read Kimberlé Crenshaw. Read Richard Delgado. Then make your argument against what they actually wrote. Anything less is not thinking. It is just reaction.

## **THE 2020-2024 EVANGELICAL RESPONSE TO CRT**

**IN 2020, AFTER GEORGE** Floyd's murder, American churches were flooded with conversations about race. Many churches, evangelical ones included, issued statements acknowledging racism and committing to change. But as soon as "critical race theory" became a cultural flashpoint — as soon as politicians and media

That shift revealed something. The commitment to racial justice was conditional — conditional on not threatening evangelical theology, not demanding structural change, not challenging evangelical leadership structures. Several leaders who had spoken about racial justice found themselves under fire from other evangelicals; some were fired from their positions, some left their denominations. The speed with which the conversation moved from "racism is wrong" to "CRT is dangerous" suggested the commitment had not been deep. The real story was not that CRT was dangerous. The real story was that evangelical institutions were terrified of any structure that would require them to acknowledge and change their own systems.

Consider what the labeling swept up: teachers who taught the honest history of America's racial past, targeted for teaching CRT; books about Black history pulled from school libraries as CRT; any acknowledgment of systemic racism, any call for diverse hiring, any mention of white privilege — all of it labeled CRT. A specific academic structure became shorthand for anything that makes white people uncomfortable about race. And many evangelical leaders, sensing the cultural moment, pivoted. Instead of continuing the conversation about racial justice, they began attacking CRT. Instead of asking how to change their institutions, they

What should have happened is not hard to state: evangelical leaders could have said they were committed to racial justice on the basis of Scripture, unconcerned with the political labeling of the conversation, committed to structural change in their own institutions. What largely happened instead was alignment with the panic and a defense of the status quo. The departures tell the story. Black evangelical pastors who had hoped 2020 would lead to change watched leadership reverse course; young evangelicals who thought the movement was bending toward justice were left disappointed. The scandal here is not that CRT exists. The scandal is that when pursuing racial justice became politically inconvenient, much of evangelical leadership abandoned it.

### THE FAILURE TO PROPHECY AND THE COST OF SAFETY

**THERE ARE WHITE EVANGELICAL** leaders with platforms — books, podcasts, speaking engagements, influence — who could speak prophetically about race, about the evangelical alignment with white nationalism, about the failures of white evangelicalism. Most of them do not. The reason is plain: prophetic speech costs something. It makes people uncomfortable. It can mean loss of audience, loss of platform, loss of income. And so leadership has chosen safety over prophecy, comfort over truth-telling, alignment with power over standing with the vulnerable.

Some have tried to thread the needle, saying things like: racism is bad, but we should not talk about systemic racism;

Some white evangelical leaders have done exactly this. They have spoken clearly about the failures of white evangelicalism, and they have lost audience; some have lost speaking engagements, some have been attacked by other evangelical leaders. But they have kept their integrity, and the right to call their speech prophetic. To see more leaders do the same would mean using platforms to say that white evangelicalism has failed, that it has aligned with forces of oppression, that it has lost credibility by valuing safety and status over justice. It would mean leaders publicly repenting for their own participation in systems of injustice, acknowledging that their success and their platforms are built on systems that oppress, and calling out other leaders who have not repented — so that the tribe would no longer protect its own at the expense of justice. This is costly. It is what prophecy costs. Without it, the institution continues as it is: comfortable, defensive, and complicit.

## **READING THE WHOLE BIBLE AS GOD STANDING WITH THE VULNERABLE**

**TO READ THE BIBLE** seriously on race, we cannot read it the way white evangelical Christianity often has — as a text that confirms what it already believes. To read it

God hears the cry of enslaved people in Egypt, not the cry of Pharaoh. God stands with Moses — a fugitive from justice who has killed an Egyptian — not with the state apparatus that maintains slavery. When Israel enters the promised land, God commands jubilee: every fiftieth year, debts forgiven, land returned to its original owners, enslaved people set free. This is not optional. It is central to the law. The prophets do not spend their time comforting the comfortable; they spend it confronting the powerful — you have taken the land of the poor, you have made slaves of the vulnerable, the Lord will judge you. In the Gospels, Jesus's first sermon announces good news to the poor, release to the prisoners, sight to the blind, freedom for the oppressed; he spends his time with the vulnerable, and with the powerful only to confront them.

Read with that lens, the whole narrative looks different from what white evangelical Christianity has taught. You see a God who is not interested in maintaining order but in establishing justice. This requires reading the Bible in its own logic rather than importing modern categories — understanding the social structure of ancient Israel, what jubilee would have meant, what it meant for women and slaves and foreigners to be included in the covenant. It requires being willing to let the text say things that challenge your power and your comfort. To read the Bible seriously on race is not to hunt for verses that support your position; it is



## THE QUESTION BENEATH THE QUESTION IS POWER

**THE ARGUMENTS ABOUT CRT** are proxy arguments. They are not really about whether CRT is academically coherent or whether intersectionality is a useful analytical tool. They are about power. The real question runs underneath: if we acknowledge systemic racism, if we acknowledge that systems were designed to benefit white people and harm Black people, if we acknowledge that white Christians have been complicit in those systems, then what does that mean for our authority, our institutions, the way we have understood ourselves?

That question cannot be stated directly, so it gets stated through arguments about CRT — through claims that it is Marxist, un-American, dangerous. But the panic reveals what is actually feared: the loss of the ability to see oneself as inherently good, to see the institutions one built as inherently good, to see America as inherently good. If systemic racism is real, if systems were designed to exclude Black people and benefit white people, then white people cannot claim innocence, white institutions cannot claim neutrality, and America cannot claim to be a simple beacon of freedom. This is the argument evangelicals cannot articulate, because

What is feared is not CRT. It is the possibility of having been on the wrong side of history, the possibility that the institutions perpetuated injustice, the possibility of having benefited from systems one claimed to oppose. That is the real conversation that needs to happen — not a debate about whether CRT is academically sound, but an honest reckoning: have we been complicit, have we benefited from injustice, are we willing to change? These are harder and costlier questions, so the debate about CRT becomes a way to avoid them. Anyone paying attention can see through it. A church that wants to do justice has to be willing to have the real argument, to ask whether it has benefited from injustice — the answer will almost certainly be yes — and then to do something about it. That, not the academic structure, is what the resistance to CRT is really about: the fear of what acknowledging the system would require.

### **WHAT OTHER CHURCHES HAVE LEARNED: SOUTH AFRICA, BRAZIL, AND THE UK**

**SOUTH AFRICA'S CHURCHES FACED** a choice during apartheid: participate, or resist. Some resisted, some collaborated. After apartheid, the ones that had resisted — churches like the Dutch Reformed Mission Church and the Anglican Church — had credibility, because they had already paid a cost for their convictions, and they became leaders in the reconciliation work that followed. The lesson is sharp: a church that keeps its power while injustice continues loses its moral authority, and a church willing to sacrifice for justice gains it.

The UK's churches have had to reckon with colonialism and immigration, and with more experience of non-white membership than many American churches, they have in some cases done better work on racism. But they also contain resistance — British nationalism, the desire to protect British identity — which can erect barriers to genuine racial justice. The lesson is that nationalism and racial justice sit in tension; a church identified with national identity will struggle to pursue justice when justice threatens that identity. American churches should learn from both the successes and the failures abroad: that the church which opposes injustice in real time has credibility, that spiritual equality without structural change is not the gospel, that nationalism and racial justice are in tension, and that reconciliation requires the perpetrator to pay a cost rather than the victim to forgive without the perpetrator changing. The most important lesson is that what the church does now shapes what it becomes. If the American church keeps choosing comfort over justice, it becomes a symbol of comfort rather than of the cross; if it is willing to sacrifice for justice, it can become a sign of what is possible when people take the gospel seriously. The choice is still in front of us.

**RECONCILIATION IS THE GOAL** white evangelicals most often hold out. It sounds like healing; it sounds like moving forward together. But reconciliation, as it is usually understood, is too small. It can mean that the oppressor and the oppressed agree to stop fighting and move on — which does not heal what was broken or restore what was taken. Cornel West offers a larger vision. He speaks of beloved community, which is more than reconciliation: it is the possibility of genuine love across difference, of people who have been enemies becoming family. This is more than white people and Black people deciding to be civil; it is the possibility of actually loving one another, caring for one another's flourishing, being willing to sacrifice for one another. The Black church kept this vision alive even when white Christianity abandoned it, believing that genuine community was possible and that enemies could become family in Christ.

But beloved community has a requirement. It asks the people who have benefited from injustice to give something up, the comfortable to become uncomfortable, the powerful to share power. Most churches are not willing. Most want reconciliation without cost — to reconcile with Black people without changing how power operates. Beloved community is not possible while white leadership keeps control, while resources stay concentrated in white hands. So what would it look like in an American church? It would look like white Christians sitting with Black Christians and hearing the stories of what was done; genuine grief over what the church has done; a willingness to make things right that goes far

It would look like a church willing to become something radically different from what it was — because beloved community is not reconciliation to the old thing; it is the creation of something new. And that points to the crisis evangelicalism cannot evade. Young people are leaving, credibility is eroding, the institution is declining. Some blame secularization, some the rise of the nones, some broad cultural trends. But the core crisis is credibility. Evangelicalism has lost moral credibility because it defended systems of injustice, and it has lost the ability to speak prophetically because it aligned itself with power. Young people see it: that evangelicals defended segregation academies while claiming to follow the Jesus who broke every boundary of separation, that evangelicals defend the existing order while claiming to follow the Jesus who cared for the poor, that evangelicals stay silent on racism while claiming to preach the whole gospel. The disconnect is real, and the young are not wrong about it.

Can evangelicalism survive without transformation? Possibly — as a subculture, as a political movement, as an institution. But it will not survive as a prophetic movement, as a credible voice on morality, as a witness to the gospel. Rebuilding that credibility would take three things. First, an honest reckoning with history: acknowledging complicity in slavery, segregation, and systemic injustice, that evangelical leaders defended these systems and evangelicals benefited

IS CRITICAL RACE THEORY BIBLICAL?